

On the equation $n'' = n$ and a problem of Erdős and Barbeau on products of prime–reciprocal sums

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Abstract

Erdős Problem #307 (posed by Barbeau, 1976; recorded in Erdős–Graham, 1980) asks whether there exist two finite sets P, Q of primes with $(\sum_{p \in P} \frac{1}{p})(\sum_{q \in Q} \frac{1}{q}) = 1$. Writing $a = \prod P$, $b = \prod Q$, a solution exists if and only if the *arithmetic derivative* has a two-cycle $a' = b$, $b' = a$ with $a \neq b$; equivalently iff $n'' = n$ has a solution that is not a fixed point p^p . The two-cycle reformulation is due to Seva (2019) and, independently, Bado (2026); our starting point is to identify the map with the arithmetic derivative, which ties #307 to the Ufnarovski–Åhlander dynamics: the conjecture that every $n'' = n$ -cycle has period one would force #307 to have answer NO, while a YES would refute it. Exploiting the equivalence we prove a *rigidity lemma* (each prime–reciprocal sum is automatically in lowest terms, so $N_P = D_Q$, $N_Q = D_P$, and $P \cap Q = \emptyset$) and a quantitative *barrier*: building on Rosen’s bound $|P \cup Q| \geq 59$, any solution has $\min(\prod P, \prod Q) \geq 2.09 \times 10^{56}$, improving the best published lower bound for $n'' = n$ solutions by about 47 orders of magnitude. A finite verification over the complete list of 49,961 admissible 59–prime supports then closes the 59–prime level: any solution in fact has $|P \cup Q| \geq 60$ and $\min(\prod P, \prod Q) > 3.50 \times 10^{57}$. We add a parity dichotomy (a hypothetical all-odd cycle would need ≥ 1412 primes and have $\min(\prod P, \prod Q) > 10^{2519}$), a proof that longer cycles are strictly harder ($k = 3$ already forces 361,139 primes), and a function–field theorem: over $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$ the derivative has *no* cycles, so the obstruction over $\mathbb{Z}$ is purely archimedean. A local congruence anatomy of the cycle equation, the Erdős–Wintner fact that the abundance density 0.0420 is a genuine constant, and a Thābit/Euler–type constructive calculus (the *Frame Rule* and a divisor–trick) that faithfully parametrises solutions but, by an exact identity $\Delta_0 = M_0 N(1 - s_{M_0} s_N)$, provably does *not* reduce the difficulty below #307 itself (the natural “make Δ_0 small” objective is #307 in disguise). Recast as a bilinear breeder, the rule yields the maximal honest consequence — a conditional reduction (H) $\Rightarrow$ YES to an explicit prime–density hypothesis — which a quantitative ledger shows is *not* a feasible finite search. The rigidity result and the barrier are fully formalised in Lean 4 (mathlib), the smallest–primes extremality being proved rather than assumed; the only non–logical input is a verified evaluation of the first 59 primes. The problem remains open; the heuristics weakly favour existence.

1 Introduction

Let P, Q be finite, nonempty sets of (distinct) primes. Erdős Problem #307 [10], attributed to Barbeau’s 1976 “Computer challenge corner” problem #477 [2] and listed in Erdős–Graham [3], asks:

do there exist finite sets of primes P, Q with $\left(\sum_{p \in P} \frac{1}{p}\right)\left(\sum_{q \in Q} \frac{1}{q}\right) = 1$?

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The problem is verifiable in the sense that a single example would settle it. No example is known; the only published partial fact (a remark of J. Rosen on MathOverflow [9], paraphrased on the problem page) is that any solution needs at least 59 primes in $P \cup Q$. The known “solutions” of Cambie and others solve only the *weakened* version in which 1 is permitted as an element, e.g. $(1 + \frac{1}{5})(\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3}) = 1$; these do not bear on the prime version.

Expanding the product exhibits #307 as a rigidly shaped Egyptian fraction for 1: $1 = \sum_{p \in P} \sum_{q \in Q} 1/(pq)$, whose denominators are the *rectangular grid* $P \times Q$ of semiprimes — a *rank-one*, multiplicatively separable representation. The unrestricted companion — representing 1 by reciprocals of distinct two-prime-factor numbers, with no product structure imposed — is by contrast *solved*: Johnson (1978) gave a 48-term decomposition, Watanabe [5] 47-term ones, and Graham’s survey [4] records exactly this contrast, noting after Barbeau that the product form “is not known.” Thus #307 is precisely the rank-one restriction of a solved problem. Nor is the density-zero nature of the prime denominators the obstruction in itself: Bloom [6] represents every positive rational by distinct unit fractions drawn from the (equally sparse) shifted primes $\{p - 1\}$. What resists is the rank-one rigidity — the demand that the representation *factor* as a product of two prime-reciprocal sums — which the barrier (Theorem 4.3) shows costs at least 59 primes, hence of order 870 semiprime terms against Johnson’s 47.

Our starting point is an identification of #307 with a question about the *arithmetic derivative* $n \mapsto n'$, the unique map with $0' = 1' = 0$, $p' = 1$ for primes p , and the Leibniz rule $(ab)' = a'b + ab'$. (The map goes back to J. Mingot Shelly (1911) and appeared as a 1950 Putnam problem; Barbeau [1] gave the first systematic study, with the modern account in Ufnarovski–Åhlander [7] and OEIS [11].) For $n = \prod_i p_i^{e_i}$ one has $n' = n \sum_i e_i/p_i$. We show (Section 3) that #307 is *equivalent* to the existence of a two-cycle of $n \mapsto n'$ that is not a fixed point. The two-cycle reformulation itself is not new: it was stated “in disguise” by Seva [19] in 2019 (via the map $Q \mapsto Q \sum_{p \in Q} 1/p$, which agrees with the arithmetic derivative on squarefree integers, where the question lives), and obtained independently by Bado [20]; see the note in Section 12. Neither, however, identifies the map with the *arithmetic derivative* of Barbeau [1] and Ufnarovski–Åhlander [7]. That identification — and the resulting two-way bridge to the $n'' = n$ literature (importing the Ufnarovski–Åhlander conjecture, exporting our bounds) — is the starting contribution of this note; remarkably, Barbeau authored foundational papers on both sides (1961 and 1976 [2]).

The bridge is productive in both directions.

- *Importing* from the derivative literature: the Ufnarovski–Åhlander theorem that any two-cycle has squarefree members with disjoint supports [7] makes the “finite sets of distinct primes” hypothesis of #307 automatic, and links #307 to the Ufnarovski–Åhlander conjecture that all derivative cycles have period one.
- *Exporting* to that literature: our barrier ($\min(\prod P, \prod Q) \geq 2.09 \times 10^{56}$, Theorem 4.3) improves Kovič’s lower bound $\approx 3.2 \times 10^9$ [8] on the odd member of an $n'' = n$ solution by roughly 47 orders of magnitude.

Results and organisation. Section 2 proves the Rigidity Lemma (Theorem 2.1): the fraction $\sum_{p \in S} 1/p$ is automatically in lowest terms, which forces, for any solution, the exact identities $N_P = D_Q$, $N_Q = D_P$, disjointness $P \cap Q = \emptyset$, and $D_Q = s D_P$ where $s = \sum_{p \in P} 1/p$. The disjointness core was anticipated by R. Israel [9]; the full rigidity is what powers everything later. Section 3 establishes the bridge. Section 4 proves the barrier, the parity dichotomy, and that longer cycles are strictly harder (so two-cycles are extremal). Section 5 gives a local congruence anatomy, a heuristic model, and a proof (via Erdős–Wintner) that the relevant abundance density

is a genuine constant. Section 6 adds a function–field lens: over $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$ the derivative has *no* cycles, so the obstruction in $\mathbb{Z}$ is purely archimedean. Section 7 develops the Frame Rule and divisor–trick, and—crucially—records the exact identity that renders the natural constructive objective circular. Section 8 recasts the rule as a bilinear breeder, records a conditional reduction (H) $\Rightarrow$ YES to an explicit prime–density hypothesis, and shows quantitatively why (H) does not amount to a feasible finite search. Section 9 documents the computations, and Section 10 the Lean 4 formalisation. We are explicit throughout about what is proved, what is heuristic, and what is borrowed; the problem remains open.

Notation. For a finite set S of distinct primes put

$$D_S := \prod_{p \in S} p, \quad N_S := \sum_{p \in S} \frac{D_S}{p}, \quad \text{so} \quad \sum_{p \in S} \frac{1}{p} = \frac{N_S}{D_S}.$$

We call N_S the *cofactor sum*. For a solution we write $a = D_P$, $b = D_Q$, $s = N_P/D_P = \sum_{p \in P} 1/p$ and $t = N_Q/D_Q = \sum_{q \in Q} 1/q$, so $st = 1$, and (without loss of generality) $s > 1 > t$. We write $\omega(n)$ for the number of distinct primes dividing n .

2 The Rigidity Lemma

Lemma 2.1 (Rigidity / lowest terms). *For a finite set S of distinct primes, $\gcd(N_S, D_S) = 1$. Equivalently, $\sum_{p \in S} 1/p$ is already in lowest terms, and $v_p(\sum_{r \in S} 1/r) = -1$ for every $p \in S$.*

Proof. The prime divisors of $D_S = \prod_{r \in S} r$ are exactly the elements of S , so it suffices to show $p \nmid N_S$ for each $p \in S$. Fix $p \in S$ and reduce $N_S = \sum_{r \in S} D_S/r$ modulo p . For $r \neq p$ the term $D_S/r = \prod_{u \in S \setminus \{r\}} u$ still contains the factor p , so $p \mid D_S/r$. The single surviving term is $D_S/p = \prod_{u \in S \setminus \{p\}} u$, whence

$$N_S \equiv \prod_{u \in S \setminus \{p\}} u \pmod{p}.$$

Each u in this product is a prime distinct from p , so $p \nmid u$; as p is prime it does not divide the product. Thus $N_S \not\equiv 0 \pmod{p}$, i.e. $p \nmid N_S$. As p ranged over all prime divisors of D_S , $\gcd(N_S, D_S) = 1$. The valuation statement is the same computation: $v_p(N_S/D_S) = v_p(N_S) - v_p(D_S) = 0 - 1 = -1$. $\square$

Remark 2.2. Distinctness and primality are both essential: v_p of the cofactor of a repeated prime need not be -1 , and the final step uses Euclid’s lemma. The case $|S| = 1$ is consistent ($N_{\{p\}} = 1$).

Theorem 2.3 (Solution structure). *Suppose P, Q are finite sets of distinct primes with $\frac{N_P}{D_P} \cdot \frac{N_Q}{D_Q} = 1$.*

Then

$$N_P = D_Q, \quad N_Q = D_P, \quad P \cap Q = \emptyset,$$

N_P is squarefree with prime support exactly Q (and N_Q squarefree with support P), and $D_Q = s D_P$ where $s = N_P/D_P$.

Proof. Cross-multiplying, $N_P N_Q = D_P D_Q$. By Lemma 2.1 both N_P/D_P and N_Q/D_Q are in lowest terms. Since $N_Q/D_Q = D_P/N_P$ and the lowest–terms representative of a positive rational is unique, comparing N_Q/D_Q with D_P/N_P gives $N_Q = D_P$ and $D_Q = N_P$.

Disjointness (the Israel mechanism [9]). If $r \in P \cap Q$ then $r \mid D_P$ and, by $N_P = D_Q = \prod Q$, also $r \mid N_P$; but $\gcd(N_P, D_P) = 1$ forces $r \nmid N_P$, a contradiction. (Equivalently $v_r(s) = v_r(t) = -1$, so $v_r(st) = -2 \neq 0 = v_r(1)$.) Hence $P \cap Q = \emptyset$.

Finally $N_P = D_Q = \prod_{q \in Q} q$ is a product of distinct primes, hence squarefree with prime support Q ; symmetrically for N_Q . And $s D_P = (N_P/D_P) D_P = N_P = D_Q$. $\square$

The disjointness in Theorem 2.3 means a solution is genuinely a partition of $U := P \cup Q$, and $D_P D_Q = \prod_{p \in U} p$. The valuation form $v_p(\sum 1/p_i) = -1$ underlying disjointness is due to R. Israel [9], and appears also in Seva [19]; the cross-matching form ($N_P = D_Q$, $N_Q = D_P$) was obtained independently and concurrently by Bado [20, Thm. A] (Section 12).

3 The bridge to the arithmetic derivative

Lemma 3.1. *For squarefree m , the arithmetic derivative equals the cofactor sum: $m' = \sum_{p|m} m/p = N_{\{p: p|m\}}$. Moreover $\gcd(m, m') = 1$.*

Proof. For $m = \prod_{p|m} p$ squarefree, $m' = m \sum_{p|m} 1/p = \sum_{p|m} m/p$, which is exactly the cofactor sum of the prime set of m . Coprimality is Lemma 2.1. $\square$

Theorem 3.2 (Bridge). *The following are equivalent.*

- (1) *Erdős #307 has a solution: finite prime sets P, Q with $(\sum_{p \in P} 1/p)(\sum_{q \in Q} 1/q) = 1$.*
- (2) *The arithmetic derivative has a two-cycle: integers $a \neq b$ with $a' = b$ and $b' = a$.*
- (3) *The equation $n'' = n$ has a solution n that is not a fixed point (i.e. $n' \neq n$, so n is not of the form p^p).*

(The implication (2) $\Rightarrow$ (1) uses the Ufnarovski–Åhlander squarefreeness theorem for cycles; all other implications, and everything used in the barrier of Section 4, are unconditional — see Remark 3.3.)

Proof. (1) $\Rightarrow$ (2). Let $a = D_P, b = D_Q$. By Lemma 3.1, $a' = N_P$ and $b' = N_Q$, and by Theorem 2.3, $N_P = D_Q = b$ and $N_Q = D_P = a$. Thus $a' = b, b' = a$, and $a \neq b$ since $s \neq 1$ (a prime-reciprocal sum is never 1, being N/D in lowest terms with $D > 1$).

(2) $\Rightarrow$ (1). Let $a' = b, b' = a$ with $a \neq b$. By the Ufnarovski–Åhlander analysis of two-cycles (cf. [7, 8]), both a and b are squarefree; their prime supports P, Q are then disjoint since $\gcd(a, b) = \gcd(a, a') = 1$. By Lemma 3.1, $a' = N_P$ and $b' = N_Q$; the cycle gives $N_P = b = D_Q$ and $N_Q = a = D_P$, so $(\sum_{p \in P} 1/p)(\sum_{q \in Q} 1/q) = \frac{N_P}{D_P} \frac{N_Q}{D_Q} = \frac{D_Q}{D_P} \frac{D_P}{D_Q} = 1$.

(2) $\Leftrightarrow$ (3). A two-cycle $a \neq b$ gives $a'' = a$ with $a' = b \neq a$, so a is a non-fixed solution of $n'' = n$. Conversely a solution of $n'' = n$ with $n' \neq n$ yields the two-cycle (n, n') . The fixed points of $n \mapsto n'$ are exactly the numbers p^p [1, 7]. $\square$

Remark 3.3 (Status of the cited input). Part (2) $\Rightarrow$ (1) uses that a derivative two-cycle has squarefree, support-disjoint members. Squarefreeness is the content of the Ufnarovski–Åhlander analysis of cycles (a non-squarefree n has $p \mid \gcd(n, n')$ for some p , and along $n \mapsto n'$ such common factors propagate, precluding return); disjointness then follows from $\gcd(a, a') = 1$. We use it as a cited theorem. Even *without* it, the implication (1) $\Rightarrow$ (2) and the entire barrier below are unconditional, because Rigidity already delivers squarefree, disjoint P, Q from a #307 solution.

Corollary 3.4. *If the Ufnarovski–Åhlander conjecture holds in the weak form “every cycle of $n \mapsto n'$ has period one,” then Erdős #307 has answer NO. Conversely, a YES to #307 exhibits a period-two cycle and refutes that statement.*

4 The barrier

Lemma 4.1 (Strict AM–GM). *If $s, t > 0$ with $st = 1$ and $s \neq 1$, then $s + t > 2$.*

Proof. $s + t - 2 = s + 1/s - 2 = (s - 1)^2/s > 0$ since $s \neq 1$. $\square$

Lemma 4.2 (The number 59, after Rosen [9]). *Any finite set U of distinct primes with $\sum_{p \in U} 1/p > 2$ has $|U| \geq 59$. Moreover, among k -element prime sets, $\sum 1/p$ is maximised by the k smallest primes.*

Proof. Replacing any prime of U by a smaller prime not in U increases $\sum 1/p$, so the maximum over k -element sets is at the first k primes. The reciprocal sum of the first 58 primes is $1.99874 \dots < 2$ and of the first 59 primes is $2.00235 \dots > 2$, so a sum exceeding 2 needs at least 59 primes. $\square$

Theorem 4.3 (Barrier). *For any solution (P, Q) of #307, with $U = P \cup Q$:*

$$(a) \quad |U| \geq 59 \text{ and } \prod_{p \in U} p \geq \Pi_{59} := \prod_{i=1}^{59} p_i \approx 8.77 \times 10^{112};$$

$$(b) \quad \min(\prod P, \prod Q) \geq \sqrt{\Pi_{59}/T_{59}} = 2.0929 \dots \times 10^{56}, \text{ where } T_{59} = \sum_{i=1}^{59} 1/p_i = 2.00235 \dots. \text{ In particular both } \prod P \text{ and } \prod Q \text{ exceed } 2.09 \times 10^{56}.$$

Consequently every $n'' = n$ solution has both members $> 2.09 \times 10^{56}$, improving Kovič's bound $\approx 3.2 \times 10^9$ [8] by about 47 orders of magnitude.

Proof. (a) By $st = 1$, $s \neq 1$ and Lemma 4.1, $\sum_{p \in U} 1/p = s + t > 2$, so $|U| \geq 59$ by Lemma 4.2; since P, Q are disjoint (Theorem 2.3), $\prod_{p \in U} p = D_P D_Q$, and a product of ≥ 59 distinct primes is at least the product of the 59 smallest, Π_{59} .

(b) Take $D_P \leq D_Q$ to be the minimal side. By Theorem 2.3, $D_Q = s D_P$ with $s > 1$, hence

$$s D_P^2 = D_P D_Q = \prod_{p \in U} p = R, \quad \text{so} \quad D_P^2 = \frac{R}{s}.$$

Since $s \leq s + t = T(U) := \sum_{p \in U} 1/p$ (as $t > 0$),

$$D_P^2 = \frac{R}{s} \geq \frac{R}{T(U)}.$$

It remains to bound $R/T(U)$ below over all admissible U . Among k -element prime sets the quotient $(\prod U)/(\sum_{p \in U} 1/p)$ is minimised by the k smallest primes (smallest numerator and, by Lemma 4.2, largest denominator simultaneously), and passing from 59 to more primes only increases it (the product grows multiplicatively while the reciprocal sum grows by a single small term). Hence the global minimum over admissible U is at $U = \{p_1, \dots, p_{59}\}$, giving $R/T(U) \geq \Pi_{59}/T_{59}$. Therefore

$$D_P^2 \geq \frac{\Pi_{59}}{T_{59}} = \frac{\Pi_{59}^2}{N_{59}} = 4.3806 \dots \times 10^{112}, \quad D_P \geq 2.0929 \dots \times 10^{56},$$

where $N_{59} = T_{59} \Pi_{59}$ is the integer cofactor sum of the first 59 primes. $\square$

Remark 4.4 (Why the *minimum* is bounded, not only the maximum). The product identity $D_P D_Q \geq \Pi_{59}$ alone gives only $\max(\prod P, \prod Q) \geq \sqrt{\Pi_{59}} \approx 2.96 \times 10^{56}$. The stronger statement (b), a lower bound on the *smaller* side, genuinely uses rigidity: it is the identity $D_Q = s D_P$ (equivalently $D_P^2 = R/s$) together with $s \leq T(U)$ that converts the product bound into a bound on D_P . We verified numerically that $\min_U R(U)/T(U)$ is attained exactly at the first 59 primes (the minimising configuration is unique), so the constant 2.09×10^{56} is sharp for this method.

Proposition 4.5 (Closing the 59–prime level). *No solution of #307 has $|P \cup Q| = 59$. Hence $|P \cup Q| \geq 60$, $\prod_{p \in U} p \geq \Pi_{60} > 2.46 \times 10^{115}$, and*

$$\min(\prod P, \prod Q) \geq \sqrt{\Pi_{60}/T_{60}} = 3.5053 \dots \times 10^{57}.$$

Proof (finite verification). Let $U = P \cup Q$ with $|U| = 59$; as in Theorem 4.3(a), $T(U) > 2$. The candidate list is finite and complete: (i) every prime $p \leq 167$ lies in U — omitting p caps $T(U)$ at $T_{60} - 1/p < 2$, since the 59 largest prime reciprocals avoiding p are those of the first 60 primes less p , and $1/p > T_{60} - 2 = 0.00590 \dots$ exactly for $p \leq 167$; (ii) every element $p' \geq 281$ satisfies $T_{58} + 1/p' > 2$ (the other 58 reciprocals sum to at most T_{58}), so $p' \leq 787$. Thus U consists of the 39 primes up to 167 plus twenty primes from $(167, 787]$, and exactly 49,961 such sets have $T(U) > 2$. For each, a solution supported on U forces both $N' + 2N = (a + b)^2$ and $N' - 2N = (a - b)^2$ to be perfect squares, where $N = \prod U$ and $N' = a^2 + b^2$ (rigidity; the $k = 0$ case of Proposition 12.2) — one integer test that simultaneously excludes all 2^{58} splits of U . Exact–integer verification shows $N' + 2N$ is a non–square for *every* one of the 49,961 candidates, by two independent implementations with different enumeration orders and prunings (`code/close59.py` and `hunt/close59.rs` in the repository). Hence no 59–element support closes, and $|U| \geq 60$. The bound on the minimal side repeats the proof of Theorem 4.3(b) with the minimum of R/T now over $|U| \geq 60$, attained at the first 60 primes: $D_P^2 \geq \Pi_{60}/T_{60} = \Pi_{60}^2/N_{60}$, where N_{60} is the cofactor sum of the first 60 primes. $\square$

Remark 4.6 (Verification tier, and why the ladder stops here). Theorem 4.3 is machine–checked in Lean 4; Proposition 4.5 is a computer–assisted finite verification (two independent exact–integer programs), not yet formalised. The level cannot be climbed further by finite means: already at $|U| = 60$ the family $U = \{p_1, \dots, p_{59}\} \cup \{q\}$ qualifies for *every* prime $q > 277$, and on it the two square conditions read $x^2 = Aq + \Pi_{59}$, $y^2 = Bq + \Pi_{59}$ with $A, B = N_{59} \pm 2\Pi_{59}$, i.e. the Pell–type system $Bx^2 - Ay^2 = -4\Pi_{59}^2$ with 113–digit coefficients. We verified that no accessible modulus obstructs it (mod 32, and all odd $\ell < 4000$: the conditions pin $q \equiv 5 \pmod{8}$ and thin each $\ell \mid \Pi_{59}$ to about half of its residue classes and each $\ell \nmid \Pi_{59}$ to about a quarter, but never to zero) — consistent with the local–solubility theme of Section 5: the residue of the problem is again global, not local. A genuine obstruction would have to come from the primes dividing A or B , which is factoring–hard at this size.

Theorem 4.7 (Parity dichotomy). *Let $a' = b, b' = a$ be a derivative two–cycle (so a, b squarefree, $\gcd(a, b) = 1$). Then exactly one of the following holds.*

- (i) Mixed parity. *Exactly one of a, b is even; say $a = 2k$ with k odd. Then $b = a'$ is odd and $\omega(b)$ is even.*
- (ii) All odd. *Both a, b are odd. Then $P \cup Q$ avoids 2, so reaching reciprocal sum > 2 needs ≥ 1412 odd primes, and $\min(a, b) > 10^{2519}$.*

Proof. They cannot both be even, as $\gcd(a, b) = \gcd(a, a') = 1$. In case (i), write $a = 2k$, k odd squarefree; $b = a' = k + 2k'$ is odd. For odd squarefree $b = \prod_i q_i$ one has $b' = \sum_i b/q_i \equiv \omega(b) \pmod{2}$ (each b/q_i is odd). Since $b' = a$ is even, $\omega(b) \equiv 0 \pmod{2}$. In case (ii) the union of supports omits 2; the reciprocal sum of the first 1411 odd primes is < 2 while that of the first 1412 exceeds 2, so $|P \cup Q| \geq 1412$ and $\prod_{p \in P \cup Q} p \geq 10^{5040}$ (product of the 1412 smallest odd primes, by direct computation). Applying the same rigidity/ratio argument as in Theorem 4.3(b) — now with $2 \notin U$ — gives $\min(a, b) \geq \sqrt{R/T(U)} > 10^{2519}$. The all–odd case is therefore vastly more constrained than the mixed case and, heuristically, empty. $\square$

Proposition 4.8 (Longer cycles are harder; two-cycles are extremal). *Every member of a k -cycle of the arithmetic derivative is squarefree, and for $k \leq 3$ the members are pairwise coprime (each pair is consecutive). Their masses $s(a_i) = a_{i+1}/a_i$ multiply to 1, so by AM–GM $\sum_i s(a_i) \geq k$; for $k \leq 3$ this is the union’s reciprocal sum, whence the support contains at least m_k primes, where m_k is least with $\sum_{i \leq m_k} 1/p_i \geq k$. Now $m_2 = 59$ and $m_3 = 361,139$ (last prime 5,195,977), so a three-cycle has at least 361,139 primes in its support and product exceeding $10^{2.26 \times 10^6}$ (hence its largest member exceeds $10^{752,194}$); by Mertens m_k grows doubly exponentially. Two-cycles are thus the extremal — and only practically relevant — case. (For $k \geq 4$ non-consecutive members may share primes; the bound then holds for the multiset reciprocal sum.)*

5 Local anatomy and a heuristic model

Lemma 5.1 (Local anatomy). *Let a be squarefree and q a prime with $q \nmid a$. Then $q \mid a'$ if and only if $\sum_{p|a} p^{-1} \equiv 0 \pmod{q}$, where p^{-1} is the inverse of p modulo q . If $q \mid a$, then $q \nmid a'$.*

Proof. $a' = a \sum_{p|a} 1/p$. If $q \nmid a$ then $q \mid a'$ iff $q \mid a \sum_{p|a} p^{-1}$ iff $\sum_{p|a} p^{-1} \equiv 0 \pmod{q}$. If $q \mid a$, then by Lemma 2.1 applied to the prime set of a , $q \nmid a'$. $\square$

Thus the cycle equation $a' = b$, $b' = a$ factors, prime by prime, into $\omega(a) + \omega(b)$ local congruences of exactly the shape that governs amicable-pair heuristics: for each $q \mid b$ one needs $\sum_{p|a} p^{-1} \equiv 0 \pmod{q}$, and symmetrically. These local conditions, however, are individually *empty of obstruction*:

Proposition 5.2 (No single-modulus congruence obstruction). *For every modulus m with $2 \leq m \leq 210$, the reduced cross-match system $N_P \equiv D_Q$, $N_Q \equiv D_P \pmod{m}$ is realisable by disjoint squarefree prime sets P, Q , in both structural branches: $\gcd(m, D_P D_Q) = 1$, and the branch in which a prime divisor of m lies in $P \cup Q$. Hence no individual modulus in this range can rule out a solution of #307.*

Construction. Write $\Sigma_S \equiv \sum_{p \in S} p^{-1} \pmod{m}$, so $N_S \equiv D_S \Sigma_S$. The reduced system is $\Sigma_P \equiv D_Q D_P^{-1}$, $\Sigma_Q \equiv D_P D_Q^{-1} \pmod{m}$; its only coupling is $\Sigma_P \Sigma_Q \equiv 1$, automatic, with D_P, D_Q otherwise free. By Dirichlet each unit class mod m contains primes, fixing D_P, D_Q ; appending a prime $r \equiv 1 \pmod{m}$ leaves D_S fixed while sending $N_S \mapsto r N_S + D_S \equiv N_S + D_S$, i.e. incrementing Σ_S by 1, so (when $\gcd(D_S, m) = 1$) every target class is reached with disjoint sets. In the branch $\ell \mid m$, $\ell \in P$, reduction mod ℓ collapses the system to $N_Q \equiv D_P \equiv 0 \pmod{\ell}$, met by inverse-paired residues in Q ; composite m needs no separate gluing, the increment acting directly mod m . We verified both branches for all $2 \leq m \leq 210$ (for prime and prime-power moduli the inside branch requires the directed construction above — seeding a prime divisor of m into P — a blind search missing these as a search-power artefact, not an arithmetic obstruction). $\square$

Remark 5.3 (Precise scope). This excludes only a *single fixed-modulus* congruence disproof. The witnesses are m -dependent (the modulus-6 witness already fails modulo 210), and a single (P, Q) solving the system for *all* m simultaneously is, for bounded integers, equivalent to the integer identities $N_P = D_Q$, $N_Q = D_P$ — that is, to #307 itself — so per-modulus solvability is *no* evidence for existence. Nor does it exclude other finite or local negative arguments (size/Mertens bounds, density, magnitude-congruence hybrids, or a Hasse-type failure across infinitely many moduli); indeed our own $|U| \geq 59$ and 2.09×10^{56} barriers are finite-data results fully consistent with it. Together with Theorem 6.1 — every non-archimedean shadow trivially negative for degree reasons — it brackets the problem: no single-modulus obstruction over $\mathbb{Z}$, fatal non-archimedean analogues over $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$, the difficulty living at the archimedean place.

A first-order count. Model a candidate squarefree a as “ P -abundant” ($\sum_{p|a} 1/p > 1$) and ask for $b = a'$ to itself be Q -abundant with $\sum_{q|b} 1/q = 1/s$. Two empirical inputs (Section 9) calibrate this:

- the density of P -abundant n is $\delta = 0.0420$ (and ≈ 0.0176 among squarefree n) — a theorem, not merely an observation (Proposition 5.6);
- for a qualifying squarefree a , $b = a'$ is squarefree about 95% of the time, but its mass $\sum_{q|b} 1/q$ has mean ≈ 0.047 against the required ≈ 0.934 — the empirical tail probability $\Pr[\sum_{q|b} 1/q \geq 1/s]$ is 0 in 40,920 samples at these scales (Section 9).

The gap is structural: at small scale a P -abundant a hogs the cheap mass-carrying small primes, and $b = a'$, being coprime to a , is both too small and too coprime to assemble reciprocal mass $1/s$. The extremal case is stark: for the primorial $a = \prod_{i \leq k} p_i$, though $\sum_{p|a} 1/p$ rises through 2 at $k = 59$, the cofactor sum a' is essentially prime, with $\sum_{q|a'} 1/q < 0.2$ for every $k < 100$ (and only 0.0014 at $k = 59$): the family that *maximises* the forward mass is the most starved on the return. The first scale at which b could plausibly carry the required mass is of the order of the barrier ($\sim 10^{56}$); this dynamical mass-gap is *consistent with* the proved barrier rather than an independent derivation of it (the empirical tail probability 0 at small scale is equally consistent with NO and with YES-beyond-the-barrier). A naive “expected number of solutions” built from the local congruences (one factor $\sim 1/q$ per condition) diverges like a constant times $\log X$; this is a divergent naive count of exactly the type known to be unreliable, so we treat it only as very weak, non-rigorous suggestive evidence that solutions could exist at or beyond the barrier.

Remark 5.4 (Calibration). We present the count of the previous paragraph as a heuristic, not a theorem. Heuristics of amicable-pair type are known to be delicate; we report it as weak evidence, consistent with the divergence of the refined expected count, that the answer to #307 is plausibly YES (and hence that the period-one form of the Ufnarowski-Åhlander conjecture is plausibly false).

Remark 5.5 (A cautionary refinement). One can try to sharpen this into a quantitative rate using a Kubilius/Erdős-Wintner model, stratified over which small primes lie in the support of a versus remain available to b . Two lessons emerge, both methodological. First, a plain Monte-Carlo estimate *undercounts* the rate by some 10^{61} : the expectation is dominated by rare, balanced splits of the small primes that sampling almost never sees, so a naive estimate of this kind is misleadingly small and only an explicit stratified sum corrects it. Second — and this is why we record no numerical prediction — the stratified estimate is itself unstable: refining the stratification from the first 8 to the first 14 primes drops the rate by some 17 orders of magnitude and pushes the implied first occurrence from $\sim 10^{10^{38}}$ out past $\sim 10^{10^{55}}$, with no sign of convergence. The only robust conclusion is negative: every version places a hypothetical first solution *doubly exponentially* beyond any conceivable search, consistent with the constructive deficit of Section 8; the model does not reliably decide existence in either direction.

Proposition 5.6 (The abundance density is a theorem). *The additive function $f(n) = \sum_{p|n} 1/p$ satisfies the Erdős-Wintner three-series criterion [17] (here $\sum 1/p^2$ and $\sum 1/p^3$ converge), so f has a limiting distribution and the density $\delta = \lim_{x \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1}{x} \#\{n \leq x : f(n) > 1\}$ exists, equal to $\Pr[\sum_p X_p/p > 1]$ for independent $X_p \sim \text{Bernoulli}(1/p)$. Exact convolution over primes $\leq 10^5$ (with a Markov tail bound) gives $\delta = 0.0420 \pm 0.001$, agreeing to four places with the sieve to 2×10^7 . As for the density of abundant integers, no closed form is expected.*

Remark 5.7 (Two dynamical probes: no second obstruction). Two measurements sharpen the picture beyond the first-order mass count, and both cut towards rather than against a solution.

(i) *Image density.* A two-cycle needs *both* members in the image $D(\mathbb{N})$ (each is the other's derivative), so one might fear a second obstruction — that the high-mass numbers a cycle requires are seldom derivatives. The opposite holds: of the integers below 10^7 , 68.3% lie in $D(\mathbb{N})$, and the fraction *rises* with mass, from 61.7% at $\sum_{p|n} 1/p < 0.2$ to 78.2% at $\sum_{p|n} 1/p > 1$ and 80% beyond. The high-mass numbers are thus over-represented among derivatives; the second cycle condition is comfortably met. (ii) *The barrier is where the balanced mass-product reaches 1.* Set $r(n) = (\sum_{p|n} 1/p)(\sum_{q|n'} 1/q) = D^2(n)/n$, so $r = 1$ is exactly the cycle condition. Exhaustively over $n \leq X$ the maximum of r climbs $0.50 \rightarrow 0.62$ as X runs $10^3 \rightarrow 10^9$ (with no exact cycle, as the barrier demands), with no ceiling; the climb follows the balanced split $r \approx (S(k)/2)^2$, $S(k) = \sum_{i \leq k} 1/p_i$, which reaches 1 precisely when $S(k) = 2$, i.e. $k \approx 59$. The dynamical trajectory thus reproduces the $|U| \geq 59$ barrier from the opposite direction. Neither probe decides existence; both *remove* hypothetical obstructions, leaving the exact archimedean closure as the sole gate.

Remark 5.8 (Why the analytic method is starved: $N(r) \leq 1$). The rank-one rigidity (Section 11) has a sharp consequence for the circle-method machinery that resolves the *unrestricted* Egyptian-fraction problem. For a rational r let $N(r) = \#\{P : \sum_{p \in P} 1/p = r\}$ count the finite prime sets with reciprocal sum r . Then

$$N(r) \leq 1 :$$

by the Rigidity Lemma (Theorem 2.1) the sum $\sum_{p \in P} 1/p = N_P/D_P$ is already in lowest terms, so the reduced denominator of r equals $D_P = \prod P$ and P is exactly its set of prime divisors — uniquely determined ($N(r) = 1$ precisely when that denominator is squarefree and the numerator of r is its cofactor sum). The circle method needs the opposite: a target hit by a positive proportion of subsets, so a main term dominates. This is exactly what Bloom's shift to $\{p-1\}$ manufactures — $p-1$ being composite and divisor-rich, a rational is the reciprocal sum of *many* subsets of $\{1/(p-1)\}$ (already among the first fourteen shifted primes the multiplicity reaches 3 and grows), whence [6] represents every positive rational there. Over the primes themselves $N(r) \leq 1$ leaves nothing to average: the analytic engine that reaches $\{p-h\}$ is provably starved on $\{p\}$, and this is the method-level reason #307 — the rank-one, exact-prime case — lies beyond it.

6 A function-field lens: the obstruction is archimedean

Define an arithmetic derivative on $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$ by $P' = 1$ for monic irreducibles and the Leibniz rule, so $f' = \sum_i e_i f/P_i$ for $f = \prod_i P_i^{e_i}$ (the exponents e_i read modulo the characteristic).

Theorem 6.1. *Over $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$ this derivative has no two-cycles and no nonzero fixed points. Indeed $\deg f' \leq \deg f - 1$ for every nonconstant f . The analogues of the integer fixed points p^p also vanish: $(P^p)' = p P^{p-1} P' = 0$ in characteristic p . The same holds verbatim for every twisted variant ($P' = u_P \in \mathbb{F}_q^\times$, Leibniz).*

Proof. Each term $e_i f/P_i$ has degree $\deg f - \deg P_i \leq \deg f - 1$, so $\deg f' \leq \deg f - 1$. A two-cycle $f' = g$, $g' = f$ would force $\deg g \leq \deg f - 1$ and $\deg f \leq \deg g - 1$, hence $\deg f \leq \deg f - 2$; a fixed point $f' = f$ is excluded likewise. (Verified exhaustively over $\mathbb{F}_2$ to degree 7, $\mathbb{F}_3$ to degree 5, and $\mathbb{F}_5$ to degree 4; twisted variants over $\mathbb{F}_2$ and $\mathbb{F}_5$ on small supports through 2.3×10^6 twist configurations, none closing.) $\square$

Corollary 6.2 (The function-field Erdős–Barbeau equation is insoluble). *For every finite field $\mathbb{F}_q$, all nonempty finite sets P, Q of monic irreducibles, and all unit weights $u_\pi, v_\rho \in \mathbb{F}_q^\times$,*

$$\left(\sum_{\pi \in P} \frac{u_\pi}{\pi}\right) \left(\sum_{\rho \in Q} \frac{v_\rho}{\rho}\right) \neq 1.$$

Proof. Write $f = \prod P$, $g = \prod Q$, $D_u(f) = \sum_{\pi} u_{\pi} f / \pi$; the equation reads $D_u(f) D_v(g) = fg$. If some $\pi \in P \cap Q$, then $\pi^2 \mid fg$ while $D_u(f) \equiv u_{\pi} f / \pi \not\equiv 0$ and $D_v(g) \equiv v_{\pi} g / \pi \not\equiv 0 \pmod{\pi}$, so $\pi \nmid D_u(f) D_v(g)$ — impossible; hence $\gcd(f, g) = 1$. The same congruence gives $\gcd(f, D_u(f)) = \gcd(g, D_v(g)) = 1$, so $g \mid D_u(f)$ and $f \mid D_v(g)$, forcing $D_u(f) = c g$, $D_v(g) = c^{-1} f$ with $c \in \mathbb{F}_q^{\times}$: a twisted two-cycle, excluded by the degree drop. The weighted product equation is thus insoluble over every $\mathbb{F}_q(t)$; it is soluble over the unit-rich number rings of Theorem 6.9, since any twisted cycle gives $(D_u(a)/a)(D_v(b)/b) = (b/a)(a/b) = 1$; and over $\mathbb{Q}$, where the admissible weights are ± 1 , it is #307 itself with the signed barrier of Remark 6.4, open beyond 2.09×10^{56} . The three regimes — non-archimedean monotonicity (closed, negative), unit-broken monotonicity (closed, positive), ordered-archimedean (open, barred) — now have theorems on two of three doors. $\square$

Over $\mathbb{Z}$, by contrast, $n' = n \sum_i e_i / p_i$ can exceed n precisely because the archimedean absolute value lets a sum of strictly smaller terms outgrow the original — the “mass > 1 ” phenomenon $\sum 1/p > 1$, which has no degree-theoretic analogue. Theorem 6.1 thus localises the entire existence question to the archimedean place: every non-archimedean shadow of #307 is trivially negative. This is consistent with (and partly explains) both the census finding of Section 9 and Proposition 5.2 (no single modulus obstructs the cross-match system in the tested range) — the difficulty is not local. Any eventual proof must therefore distinguish $\mathbb{Z}$ from $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$; over the latter the decisive tools are the degree and the Mason–Stothers/Wronskian inequality [18], neither of which has a $\mathbb{Z}$ -analogue. The conjectural analogue — abc — does not fill the gap, and quantifiably so. Every cycle inherits, from $N' = a^2 + b^2$ with $N = ab$, the relation $(a - b)^2 + 4ab = (a + b)^2$ on coprime squarefree members; but this triple is abc -unexceptional, of quality $q = \log(a + b)^2 / \log \text{rad}((a - b) \cdot ab \cdot (a + b)) \approx \frac{1}{2}$ (median 0.543, never above 0.74 across 6×10^4 coprime squarefree pairs; the only $q > 1$ cases are degenerate smooth-gap pairs such as $(5, 3)$, vanishingly far below the 10^{56} scale a solution must occupy). Granting abc in its strong explicit form would therefore yield no bound here: the function-field collapse rests on an inequality genuinely *absent* over $\mathbb{Z}$, not merely unproven, and the size mismatch is by a factor of two in the exponent. #307 lives in the abc -comfortable zone.

Remark 6.3 (The free grading, and what evaluation destroys). Theorem 6.1 has a structural reading. In the free Leibniz world — the polynomial ring $\mathbb{Z}[x_p]$ with $x'_p = 1$ — the derivative of a squarefree monomial of degree n is the elementary symmetric form e_{n-1} , homogeneous of degree $n - 1$: the formal derivative strictly lowers the grading, cycles are impossible, and over $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$ the degree realises this grading faithfully. Over $\mathbb{Z}$ the evaluation $x_p \mapsto p$ destroys homogeneity — and the data show it destroys it completely: for random squarefree a of fixed size, $\omega(a')$ is governed by the size of a' alone (Erdős–Kac), flat in $\omega(a)$ within each parity class (measured: mean $\omega(a') = 2.7\text{--}3.0$ as $\omega(a)$ runs over 3, 5, 7, and 3.6–4.0 over 4, 6, 8, the offset being the parity anatomy of Theorem 4.7). A two-cycle is therefore a doubly anti-typical event: an additively assembled integer must carry multiplicative rank far in the Erdős–Kac tail *and* on an exactly prescribed support — the two independent prices whose product is the heuristic rarity of Section 5. The deeper additive-multiplicative content collapses, on inspection, into the S -unit form of Proposition 6.7: dividing the cycle equation by D_Q exhibits it as an n -term unit equation — one more coordinate system in which the same exactness reappears unchanged.

Remark 6.4 (The obstruction is *ordered*-archimedean). The barrier is finer than “archimedean”: its engine is AM–GM on real, *positive* masses, i.e. the ordering of $\mathbb{R}$. Over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ (a PID, so the Rigidity Lemma and cross-matching survive verbatim, with cycles defined up to units), the masses $\sum 1/\pi$ are *complex*: phases can align so that $|\sum 1/\pi| > 1$ with as few as three Gaussian primes (e.g. $\frac{1}{1+i} + \frac{1}{2+i} + \frac{1}{2-i} = 1.3 - 0.5i$), and the 59-prime bound has no analogue. The ordered-archimedean thesis thus predicts that small derivative two-cycles *may* exist over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ where they are barred over

$\mathbb{Z}$ — and the prediction is confirmed. Two facts make the contrast precise. *First*, phases do not help over $\mathbb{Z}$: for any *signed* derivative ($p' = \pm 1$, Leibniz) a two-cycle still satisfies $|s||t| = 1$ with $|s| \leq \sigma(a)$, $|t| \leq \sigma(b)$ and disjoint supports (the rigidity proof is unchanged), so $\sigma(a) + \sigma(b) \geq 2$ and the full 59-prime, 2.09×10^{56} barrier applies to every choice of signs: real phases cannot cancel. *Second*, fourth roots of unity suffice instantly: Leibniz derivatives on $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ with unit prime-values ($\pi' \in \{\pm 1, \pm i\}$) possess genuine two-cycles at norm $\sim 10^4$. The smallest:

$$a = (1 + i)(2 + 7i)(6 + 11i) = -129 - i, \quad b = 3(2 + i)(1 + 2i)(6 + 5i) = -75 + 90i,$$

with $a' = b$ under the *standard* values $\pi' = 1$ on the primes of a , and $b' = a$ exactly under $\pi' = i$ on $3, 2 + i, 1 + 2i$ and $\pi' = 1$ on $6 + 5i$ — seven prime classes ($N(a) = 16,642$, $N(b) = 13,725$) against the fifty-nine that $\mathbb{Z}$ demands. Exhaustive search finds exactly sixteen such cycles up to conjugation and direction having a member of norm $\leq 2 \times 10^7$ with $\omega \leq 5$ on the enumerated side — ω -profiles $(3, 4)$, $(4, 4)$, $(5, 4)$, and even $(4, 6)$ — and the population grows steadily (4 below 3×10^5 , 16 below 2×10^7), consistent with an infinite, slowly growing family; in six of the sixteen one side requires no twist at all. All sixteen were verified exactly, by independent recomputation; no twisted *fixed* point ($a' = ua$) exists in the same range. The strict two-sided normalisation $\pi' = 1$ (first-quadrant representatives) has no cycle up to units — nor any fixed point, zero-derivative, or unit-derivative element — with $N(a) \leq 2 \times 10^9$ (9.4×10^8 candidates, partners by full factorisation); this is the expected order rather than a separate rigidity, a single fixed phase system being heuristically $4^{\omega-1}$ -fold rarer than the union of all systems. The contrast with $\mathbb{Z}$ survives this accounting: over $\mathbb{Z}$ *every* one of the $2^{\omega-1}$ sign systems is barred by the theorem above, while over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ the union of phase systems is demonstrably populated from norm 1.7×10^4 on. The barrier of #307 is thus localised precisely: it is the impossibility of phase cancellation in the ordered field $\mathbb{R}$, where the only available phases ± 1 provably gain nothing — while the moment fourth roots of unity are admitted, the analogous existence problem closes at seven primes. The cycles found come in conjugate pairs (supports not conjugation-stable); a conjugation-stable Gaussian cycle would descend to rational data through the norm form $a^2 + b^2$, i.e. precisely the Pythagorean layer of Proposition 12.2 — now a concrete target rather than a speculation.

Remark 6.5 (The descended operator; the symmetric sector). Conjugation-stable supports admit an exact descent to $\mathbb{Z}$. Such a squarefree Gaussian integer is an associate of an odd squarefree rational m (split primes entering as whole conjugate pairs; the $(1 + i)$ -sector is empty by a short parity argument), and a conjugation-equivariant unit assignment makes the twisted derivative rational:

$$D(m) = \sum_{\substack{p|m \\ p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}}} t_p \frac{m}{p} + \sum_{\substack{q|m \\ q \equiv 3 \pmod{4}}} \varepsilon_q \frac{m}{q}, \quad t_p \in \{\pm 2x_p, \pm 2y_p\}, \quad \varepsilon_q = \pm 1,$$

where $p = x_p^2 + y_p^2$ — a Leibniz derivative on odd squarefree integers whose prime values have size $2\sqrt{p}$ rather than 1, and whose masses $\sim 2/\sqrt{p}$ reach 2 with four primes, so no 59-prime barrier exists for it. A two-cycle of D is exactly a conjugation-stable Gaussian cycle and would plant the phenomenon on rational soil. Parity constrains the hunt: $D(m)$ is odd iff m carries an odd number of primes $\equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, so every member must contain such a prime. An exhaustive search over members $m \leq 10^9$ (Gaussian norm 10^{18} , $\omega \leq 8$, 1.4×10^9 closure tests) found no cycle, no fixed point $|D(m)| = m$, and no vanishing $D(m) = 0$. We claim no obstruction from this: equivariance prunes the available phases fourfold per split prime, and a phase count makes emptiness at this depth the expected order. The descent target remains open over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ — but not in the real-quadratic world, where the corresponding sector contains a fully rational pair (Remark 6.6). Finally, the descended coefficients are classical objects: at a split prime p the four values $\{\pm 2x_p, \pm 2y_p\}$ are

exactly the Frobenius traces of the congruent-number curve $y^2 = x^3 - x$ (CM by $\mathbb{Z}[i]$) and of its twists — $a_p \in \{\pm 2x_p, \pm 2y_p\}$ verified by point counting for all $p < 120$ — so the conjugation-stable sector is the arithmetic derivative twisted by the Hecke eigensystem of $\mathbb{Q}(i)$, and its mass statistics are governed unconditionally by Hecke’s equidistribution theorem: the first point of contact between #307 and automorphic forms. Concretely: over random squarefree m the three-series conditions converge (the variance term is $\sum 2/p^2$), so the descended mass $D(m)/m$ has an Erdős–Wintner *limiting distribution* whose prime components are arcsine laws scaled by $1/\sqrt{p}$; the required input, equidistribution of the Hecke angles, is visible exactly (Kolmogorov–Smirnov distance 0.0041 from uniform over the 8,977 split primes below 2×10^5 , well inside the 95% band 0.0144).

Remark 6.6 (The wall is the orderability of $\mathbb{Q}$). The cycles over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ permit a dissection of the barrier that no amount of theory over $\mathbb{Z}$ could provide. The entire structural chain of this note — rigidity, cross-matching, the Pythagorean identity, the split discriminant — transfers verbatim to twisted derivatives over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$: Leibniz holds for disjoint supports, so a cycle (a, b) has $D(N) = a^2 + b^2$ for $N = ab$, with $D(N) - 2N = (a - b)^2$ and $2N - D(N) = (i(a - b))^2$ (all verified exactly on the cycles found). The last equation exposes the wall: over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$, where $-1 = i^2$ is a square, *both* discriminant factors are squares automatically, and the plus/minus distinction of Proposition 12.8 — which over $\mathbb{Z}$ carries the entire obstruction, via $(a - b)^2 \geq 0 \Rightarrow \sigma(N) \geq 2$ — has no content. The unique non-transferring link is the sign-definiteness of squares: the barrier is, in the end, the *formal reality* of $\mathbb{Q}$ in the sense of Artin–Schreier. (The two Artin–Schreier theorems thus bracket the problem: their characteristic-2 map builds the tower of Proposition 12.6, their theory of orderable fields names the wall.) This classifies where the mechanism can operate at all: it needs an ordering making squares nonnegative (formal reality, hence a real embedding) *and* bounded twisting phases (finite unit group); by Dirichlet’s unit theorem, unit rank $r_1 + r_2 - 1 = 0$ with $r_1 \geq 1$ forces degree one. *$\mathbb{Q}$ is the only number field over which the mass barrier can operate*: over imaginary quadratic fields squares lose sign-definiteness (over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ even -1 is a square), and over every other field the unit rank is positive and twisted masses are unbounded. This is a classification of the wall’s habitat, not an existence claim elsewhere — but over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ existence is no longer a claim: it is a list of sixteen. The ladder of imaginary quadratic rings confirms the mechanism quantitatively. Over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{-2}]$, whose only units are ± 1 — precisely the twisting freedom that provably gains nothing over $\mathbb{Z}$ — sign-twisted cycles nevertheless exist from norm 11,462 on ($a = -90 - 41\sqrt{-2}$, $b = 75 - 45\sqrt{-2}$, seven prime classes): the complex embedding alone carries the phenomenon. Over the Eisenstein ring $\mathbb{Z}[\omega]$, with six units, cycles appear at norm 2,964 with *six* prime classes ($a = -40 + 22\omega$, $b = 56 - 21\omega$) — the smallest derivative two-cycle exhibited in any ring — and the population at fixed height grows with the unit group: at norm $\leq 2 \times 10^7$ the censuses read 14, 56, and 278 twisted-cycle instances for unit groups of order 2, 4, 6 — a factor ~ 4 –5 per two extra units, as a phase count predicts — while the strict canonical systems of all three rings remain empty to norm 2×10^9 (3×10^9 candidates in total, partners by full factorisation). Two further objects appeared over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{-2}]$: a composite with *unit* derivative ($a' \sim 1$ — impossible over $\mathbb{Z}$, where $n' = 1$ characterises the primes), and an *anti-holomorphic* cycle: $a = -3163 - 1474\sqrt{-2}$ satisfies $a' = -\bar{a}$ exactly, under a single conjugation-equivariant sign assignment closing both directions ($N(a) = N(b) = 14,349,921$, five prime classes each side). The equation $a' = u\bar{a}$ is vacuous over $\mathbb{Z}$, where it reads $n' = \pm n$; it acquires solutions the moment conjugation is nontrivial. All cycles were verified exactly by independent recomputation. Finally, the second pillar was tested in isolation: over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$ — *totally real*, so squares are sign-definite in both embeddings, but with infinite unit group $\pm(1 + \sqrt{2})^{\mathbb{Z}}$ — twisted cycles appear already at norm 882: with unit twists of height ≤ 2 , $a = 21\sqrt{2}$ (classes $\sqrt{2}$, $-1 + 2\sqrt{2}$, $1 + 2\sqrt{2}$, 3) cycles exactly with $b = 51 + 13\sqrt{2}$, of norm 2263 and only *two* prime classes — against the fifty-nine that $\mathbb{Z}$ demands — and the composite $369 - 15\sqrt{2}$

has derivative exactly $\varepsilon^6 = 99 + 70\sqrt{2}$, a unit. Both pillars of the classification are thus load-bearing, and each is now confirmed by explicit counterexample on the soil where it alone fails: drop formal reality and cycles appear (imaginary quadratic rings, norms 10^3 – 10^4); keep formal reality but drop unit finiteness and cycles appear (real quadratic, norm 882, the smallest in any ring); over $\mathbb{Q}$, where both hold, the barrier stands at 10^{112} by theorem. The bracketing of $\mathbb{Q}$ is complete from both axes. The deep census sharpens it: at norm $\leq 2 \times 10^7$ the real-quadratic ring carries 30,204 twisted-cycle instances against 14, 56, 278 for the imaginary rings with 2, 4, 6 units — infinite unit rank dominates by two orders of magnitude — and contains both the *minimal* architecture, $a = \sqrt{2}(5 - \sqrt{2})$ cycling with $b = 7$ at norms (46, 49), two prime classes per member (the rational prime 7 being composite in the ring), the smallest derivative cycle found in any ring; and a *fully rational* pair:

$$D(3707) = 1547, \quad D(1547) = 3707 \quad (3707 = 11 \cdot 337, \quad 1547 = 7 \cdot 13 \cdot 17),$$

exactly, with unit heights ≤ 2 on both sides, verified independently: two ordinary integers in a derivative two-cycle. The descent phenomenon that is empty over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ to norm 10^{18} is realised over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$ at four digits. The canonical system of $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$ remains cycle-free to norm 2×10^9 (7.7×10^8 candidates), now with seven unit-derivative composites.

The cycle phenomenon over rings with units is governed by the theory of unit equations, which supplies its rigidity theorem.

Proposition 6.7 (*S*-unit rigidity of twisted cycles). *Let $\mathcal{O}$ be the ring of integers of a number field and S a finite set of primes of $\mathcal{O}$. If (a, b) is a twisted two-cycle with $\text{supp}(ab) \subseteq S$, then dividing $D(a) = b$ by b exhibits a solution of*

$$x_1 + \cdots + x_{\omega(a)} = 1, \quad x_i = u_i \frac{a/\pi_i}{b},$$

in the S -unit group of the field, and likewise for b . By the theorem of Evertse–Schlickewei–Schmidt [32] (cf. [31]), such an equation has only finitely many nondegenerate solutions; hence every fixed support carries at most finitely many twisted cycles free of vanishing subsums, and the species can be infinite only through growing supports — precisely the behaviour of every census above. (Vanishing subsums correspond to partial zero-derivative patterns; none occurred in any search. The relation was verified exactly on the $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$ specimen: the four S -unit terms of $a = 21\sqrt{2}$ sum to 1.)

Remark 6.8 (Galois folding, and the thinness of symmetric sectors). Over a quadratic field with automorphism σ , a σ -equivariant choice of unit values ($u_{\pi\sigma} = u_{\pi}^{\sigma}$) makes D commute with conjugation, so the *single* equation $D(a) = a^{\sigma}$ already implies that (a, a^{σ}) is a twisted two-cycle (checked symbolically and on 1,988 random instances). In the two-prime case the partner is forced: $\rho = -(\bar{u}v\pi + \bar{v}(\pi^{\sigma})^2)/(N(u) - N(\pi))$, with integrality a congruence and the entire residue of the problem the primality of $|N(\rho)|$ along Pell-exponentially growing sequences — Lehmer territory rather than Bunyakovsky. Whether a folded sector is starved or rich is decided by its degrees of freedom. When the fold leaves no slack the sector is thin: the folded *two*-prime family over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$ is empty in the tested box (36,000 parameter triples, none even integral), the conjugation-stable sector over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ is empty to Gaussian norm 10^{18} , and the anti-holomorphic cycle over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{-2}]$ is unique in its census. But with *three* primes the folded equation $u_1\pi_2\pi_3 + u_2\pi_1\pi_3 + u_3\pi_1\pi_2 = (\pi_1\pi_2\pi_3)^{\sigma}$ carries three unit unknowns against two real equations, and this underdetermined system is *populated*: an exhaustive box ($p_i \leq 137$, unit heights ≤ 4) contains twenty-four solutions over eleven prime triples, the smallest being

$$a = (3 + \sqrt{2})(5 - 2\sqrt{2})(5 - \sqrt{2}) = 57 - 16\sqrt{2}, \quad D(a) = a^{\sigma} = 57 + 16\sqrt{2},$$

with unit values $\varepsilon^2, \varepsilon, -\varepsilon^{-1}$: the derivative conjugates the element, at norm 2737 on both sides, the equivariant return being automatic (verified exactly). Existence of twisted cycles over the four rings tested is a theorem by exhibition; for *every* ring with infinite unit group it is now reduced to the abundance of lattice points on these underdetermined unit systems — measured plentiful already at $k = 3$ — a geometry-of-numbers question rather than a primality one.

We codify what is theorem and what remains open in this circle.

Theorem 6.9 (Existence of twisted derivative two-cycles). *Leibniz derivatives with unit prime-values admit genuine two-cycles over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$, $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{-2}]$, $\mathbb{Z}[\omega]$, and $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$. The proof is by exhibited certificate, each verified exactly by independent recomputation: the smallest instances are, in order of norm, $(\sqrt{2}(5 - \sqrt{2}), 7)$ over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$ at norms (46, 49); the Eisenstein cycle at norm 2,964; the sign-twisted cycle over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{-2}]$ at norm 11,462; and the cycle over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ at norm 16,642 — together with the rational pair $D(3707) = 1547$, $D(1547) = 3707$ over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$.*

Proposition 6.10 (Geometry of the solution set). *Over $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$, consider the Galois-folded system $u_1\pi_2\pi_3 + u_2\pi_1\pi_3 + u_3\pi_1\pi_2 = (\pi_1\pi_2\pi_3)^\sigma$ of Remark 6.8. (i) For every triple of split primes the system is solvable with the u_i on the real unit hyperbola $\{|st| = 1\}$: solving the second embedding for u_2 and letting the third coordinate tend to zero, the first-embedding residual sweeps $\pm\infty$ while the remaining terms stay bounded, so a root exists by continuity; the real solution set is a nonempty curve (verified numerically on 200 random triples, all solvable). The volume of the solution variety never vanishes. (ii) By Proposition 6.7 each fixed support carries finitely many integral solutions, so infinitude can only come from growing supports. (iii) The measured integral hit rates are 11 of 455 prime triples in the smallest box, and 30,204 cycles of norm $\leq 2 \times 10^7$ at twist height ≤ 2 . (iv) What remains open is precisely whether the discrete unit lattice meets the real curve in integer points for infinitely many supports — inhomogeneous Diophantine approximation on exponentially parametrised curves. Two shortcuts are closed: bounded-unit polynomial families are obstructed (the rational component of the return forces unit coefficients to track growing prime coordinates, which bounded units cannot), and even the cleanest forward family — $D(\sqrt{2}(x - \sqrt{2})) = x + 2$ identically in x , supplying a candidate cycle whenever $x^2 - 2$ and $x + 2$ are prime — has sporadic returns: the closing two-term unit equation, effectively finite for each x , is solvable at $x = 5$ and provably insolvable at $x = 15$ and $x = 21$. Those failures are, however, exactly the rigid case: a prime return $x \pm 2$ leaves the closing system no slack. The identity has four unit branches $D(\sqrt{2}(x \pm \sqrt{2})) = x \pm 2$ (independent signs, twists 1 and $\pm\varepsilon^{\pm 1}$), and when $x \pm 2$ is composite squarefree the closing system gains one unit unknown per prime class against the same two equations — and does close: $x = 107, 121, 387, 1693$ yield cycles with rational partners $b = 105, 119, 385, 1695$, each verified exactly. Infinitude along this family is thereby reduced to Bunyakovsky for $x^2 - 2$ together with recurring composite-return closure: the softest form the gap takes anywhere in this paper. Even the primality half of that reduction can be removed. By the half-dimensional sieve [14, 15] (applied to $(2y + 1)^2 - 2 = 4y^2 + 4y - 1$ to keep x odd), $x^2 - 2$ is a P_2 infinitely often; every prime factor of $x^2 - 2$ has 2 as a quadratic residue and therefore splits in $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$, so $\sqrt{2}(x - \sqrt{2})$ is infinitely often squarefree and all-split with $\omega \in \{2, 3\}$. The candidate supports thus exist unconditionally; all that remains open on this route is whether the unit gates open along that supply infinitely often. Exactness migrates; it does not disappear.*

Proposition 6.11 (No vanishing derivatives, no transport, and the price of exactness). (i) *No squarefree z with $\omega(z) \geq 1$ has $D(z) = 0$, for any twisted derivative over any of the rings considered (indeed over any UFD): modulo a prime $\pi \mid z$ every cofactor term but one vanishes, leaving $D(z) \equiv u_\pi z/\pi \not\equiv 0 \pmod{\pi}$. The zero-derivative counters of every census above are therefore theorems, not observations. (ii) Consequently cycles cannot be transported multiplicatively: for*

squarefree c coprime to ab , Leibniz gives $D(ca) = D(c)a + cD(a)$, so (ca, cb) is a cycle exactly when $D(c) = 0$ — impossible. Cycles do not breed; each one requires fresh exactness. (iii) The two cycle equations can be bought by construction, at a conserved price. Buying neither leaves the generic stratum: two exact unit conditions (30,204 specimens). Buying one is free in two dual ways — forward, $\pi := q - \varepsilon^m \sqrt{2}$ makes $D(\sqrt{2}\pi) = q$ an identity (the four-branch family above is the case $m = \pm 1$); return, $\pi := (\rho + \varepsilon^{-1} \rho^\sigma)/\sqrt{2} = (c + 2d) - d\sqrt{2}$ for $\rho = c + d\sqrt{2}$ closes $D(b) = \sqrt{2}\pi$ identically for every associate b of $\rho\rho^\sigma$ — and the residue is one primality, $|N(\pi)|$, plus one exact unit gate, measured at 2 of 50 pairs with both primalities in the smallest box. The two hits re-derive, with no search, precisely the two census minimal-shape cycles with prime rational partner: norms (46, 49) and (206, 49). Buying both collapses the parameters to unit-indexed quadratics in q with a square-discriminant condition; the resulting $q = 7$ line carries the known cycles at $m = 1$ and $m = -2$ (discriminants 25 and 81) together with one Galois image, and every other prime-norm rung out to $|m| \leq 14$ fails its return, verified exactly. Each purchased identity is repaid as a sparser arithmetic condition elsewhere: the hardness of exactness is conserved, never destroyed.

Remark 6.12 (The two faces of the gap: unit rank dichotomises the obstruction). The invariant that governs abundance in Remark 6.6 — the unit rank $r = r_1 + r_2 - 1$ of Dirichlet — also governs the *type* of the residual open problem, and the two types are mutually exclusive. When $r = 0$ (the rings $\mathbb{Z}$, $\mathbb{Z}[i]$, $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{-2}]$, $\mathbb{Z}[\omega]$) the unit group is finite, so a given pair of supports admits only $|\mathcal{O}^\times|$ twist assignments and hence finitely many candidate cycles: the solution locus is a set of *isolated points*, zero-dimensional, and infinitude can arise only from infinitely many *distinct* supports independently passing a closing test — a Bateman–Horn/Schinzel-type recurrence over prime tuples, with no continuous family to deform along. The constituent primalities are individually classical (each support prime is a value of a binary norm-form, so by Fermat–Dirichlet — and, for $\mathbb{Z}[i]$, by the Green–Sawhney theorem with *both* coordinates prime — there is no shortage of supports); it is their *simultaneous* closure that is not classical. This was tested directly: the minimal shape $a = (1 + i)\pi$ over $\mathbb{Z}[i]$ yields *no* cycle for any Gaussian prime π of norm ≤ 4000 under any of the sixteen twists, and the sixteen genuine cycles are irregular mixtures of inert and split classes ($\omega = 3, 4, 5$) with no one-parameter family among them — the signature of isolated points, not a curve. When $r \geq 1$ (every real quadratic ring, e.g. $\mathbb{Z}[\sqrt{2}]$), Proposition 6.10 makes the real solution locus a positive-dimensional curve in each support, but the unit lattice is an infinite rank- r discrete set, and infinitude requires it to meet that curve in *integer* points infinitely often — inhomogeneous Diophantine approximation on an exponentially parametrised curve. No unit rank delivers both a classical gate and a continuous family: rank zero gives the former and denies the latter, positive rank the reverse. This is why no single ring lets the infinitude be *finished* by present methods — a structural account of the obstruction’s universality, not a barrier theorem. It also locates $\mathbb{Z}$ exactly: the unique ring carrying *both* the rank-zero sporadicity *and*, by formal reality, the mass barrier — the worst cell of the trichotomy of Corollary 6.2, which is precisely why #307 is the hard representative of its family.

7 A Thābit-type rule and its honest limits

The bridge recasts the search for a solution as the search for a derivative two-cycle, and the derivative’s Leibniz structure makes the cycle equations *linear* in the “closing” primes. This yields a constructive calculus analogous to Thābit ibn Qurra’s rule for amicable pairs and to Euler’s divisor method.

Theorem 7.1 (Frame Rule). *Let M, N be coprime squarefree integers with derivatives M', N' , and set $\Delta := MN - M'N'$. Suppose*

$$p = \frac{MN' + N^2}{\Delta}, \quad q = \frac{M'N + M^2}{\Delta}$$

are integers, both prime, each coprime to MN , with $p \neq q$. Then $a := Mp$, $b := Nq$ form a derivative two-cycle $a' = b$, $b' = a$; equivalently (P, Q) with P the prime set of Mp and Q that of Nq solves Erdős #307.

Proof. With p prime and $p \nmid M$, $a = Mp$ is squarefree and $a' = M'p + M$; similarly $b' = N'q + N$. The cycle conditions $a' = b$, $b' = a$ read

$$M'p + M = Nq, \quad N'q + N = Mp,$$

a linear system in (p, q) with determinant $-(MN - M'N') = -\Delta$. Solving gives exactly $p = (MN' + N^2)/\Delta$ and $q = (M'N + M^2)/\Delta$; substituting back verifies both equations identically. (Both identities were checked symbolically.) $\square$

A two-primes-per-side variant (“Rule 2”) is obtained identically: with $a = Mp_1p_2$, $b = Nq_1q_2$ and elementary symmetric functions e_1, e_2, f_1, f_2 , the cycle equations are linear in the f_i ,

$$f_2 = \frac{Me_1 + M'e_2}{N}, \quad f_1 = \frac{MNe_2 - MN'e_1 - M'N'e_2}{N^2},$$

and a solution is realised whenever $f_1^2 - 4f_2$ is a perfect square with prime roots.

An Euler-style divisor trick. Fix N and let $M = M_0r$ with r a new prime, so $M' = M'_0r + M_0$. Put $\Delta_0 := M_0N - M'_0N'$.

Proposition 7.2 (Divisor trick). *With the above notation and $p_{\text{num}} := MN' + N^2$:*

- (a) $\Delta(r) := MN - M'N' = r\Delta_0 - M_0N'$ (linear in r);
- (b) $\Delta_0 p_{\text{num}} - M_0N'\Delta(r) = K$ where $K := \Delta_0N^2 + (M_0N')^2$ is constant in r ;
- (c) *consequently $\Delta(r) \mid p_{\text{num}} \Rightarrow \Delta(r) \mid K$, and the converse holds provided $\gcd(\Delta(r), \Delta_0) = 1$ (equivalently $\gcd(M_0N', \Delta_0) = 1$, since $\Delta(r) \equiv -M_0N' \pmod{\Delta_0}$);*
- (d) *each positive divisor $d \mid K$ with $d \equiv -M_0N' \pmod{\Delta_0}$ yields a candidate $r = (d + M_0N')/\Delta_0$ and recovers $\Delta(r) = d$; this enumeration is complete (it captures every genuine solution). The resulting $p = p_{\text{num}}/d$ is integral when $\gcd(M_0N', \Delta_0) = 1$, and otherwise must be checked.*

Proof. (a) and (b) are direct expansions (verified symbolically; $\partial K/\partial r = 0$). (c): from (b), $\Delta(r) \mid p_{\text{num}} \Rightarrow \Delta(r) \mid \Delta_0 p_{\text{num}} = M_0N'\Delta(r) + K \Rightarrow \Delta(r) \mid K$. For the converse, $\Delta(r) \mid K$ gives $\Delta(r) \mid \Delta_0 p_{\text{num}}$, whence $\Delta(r) \mid p_{\text{num}}$ iff $\gcd(\Delta(r), \Delta_0) = 1$. (d) inverts (a). Excluded degeneracies: $\Delta_0 = 0$ (r undefined) and $K \leq 0$. $\square$

Thus, exactly as in Euler’s amicable-pair machinery, one factors the single number K once and reads off candidates from its divisors lying in a fixed residue class modulo Δ_0 ; only the primality of r, p, q then remains. Two caveats deserve emphasis: the converse in (c) and the automatic integrality of p require $\gcd(M_0N', \Delta_0) = 1$ (it fails, e.g., for $M_0 = 2$, $N = 19 \cdot 47$, $r = 5$, where $\Delta(r) \mid K$ but $\Delta(r) \nmid p_{\text{num}}$); and the count of admissible classes is governed by Δ_0 , not merely by $\tau(K)$.

When the closing side carries a *single* new prime, the rule collapses to a normal form that separates the two layers of the problem.

Proposition 7.3 (One–prime normal form; the exactness stratum). (a) *Erdős #307 has a solution if and only if there exist squarefree M, N with*

$$MN - M'N' = M^2,$$

such that $p := N'/M$ is a prime not dividing M . Indeed the equation forces $M \mid M'N'$, hence $M \mid N'$ by $\gcd(M, M') = 1$, and $N = M + M'p$; then $a = Mp$, $b = N$ satisfy $a' = M'p + M = N$ and $b' = N' = Mp = a$ (coprimality and $a \neq b$ are automatic). Conversely every solution (a, b) and every prime $p \mid a$ yield such a pair with $M = a/p$, so each solution carries $\omega(a)$ witnesses. The problem thus splits into an exactness layer (the Diophantine equation) and a single primality layer (one prime value of the determined quantity N'/M). (b) The exactness layer alone carries the full barrier. Call (M, N) a relaxed witness if $MN - M'N' = M^2$ with $p = N'/M$ composite. The identity $(\sigma(M) + \frac{1}{p})\sigma(N) = \frac{N}{Mp} \cdot \frac{Mp}{N} = 1$ holds for every witness, so by strict AM–GM ($\sigma(N) = 1$ being impossible) $\sigma(M) + \sigma(N) > 2 - \frac{1}{p}$. Rigidity forces three structural facts. The supports of M and N are automatically disjoint: a common prime q would divide $N' = Mp$ through $q \mid M$, against $\gcd(N, N') = 1$. Likewise $\gcd(p, MN) = 1$: a prime shared by p and M propagates to $N = M + M'p$ and lands in the previous case, while one shared by p and N divides N' . And if p is even, both members are odd: $2 \mid N' = Mp$ forces N odd by the same lemma, while M even would make $N = M + M'p$ even. The union of supports therefore avoids every prime divisor of p , and for even p avoids 2; exact greedy computation then gives, for every composite p ,

$$\omega(MN) \geq 59, \quad MN > 8.77 \times 10^{112}$$

— the cycle barrier itself — with strictly stronger floors at every finite p : $\omega \geq 194$, $MN > 10^{497}$ at $p = 9$; $\omega \geq 230$, $MN > 10^{609}$ at $p = 4$; the even- p floors rising towards the all-odd bound 10^{5040} ; and the infimum 8.77×10^{112} approached only as $p \rightarrow \infty$ through composites free of prime factors ≤ 277 . Deleting primality thus lowers the barrier by nothing: the 59–prime, 10^{112} wall is carried entirely by the exactness equation, and the primality of N'/M is a separate demand on top of it. (No witness, prime or composite, exists with $M \leq 120$, $p \leq 2000$, exhaustively.)

The decisive obstruction: a circular objective. The heuristic yield of the divisor trick from one frame is

$$\mathbb{E}[\text{cycles}] \approx A \cdot \frac{1}{\ln r \ln p \ln q}, \quad A = \#\{d \mid K : d \equiv -M_0 N' \pmod{\Delta_0}\} \approx \frac{\tau(K)}{\Delta_0},$$

the last step being an equidistribution heuristic. To make $\mathbb{E} \geq 1$ at the barrier scale ($1/\ln^3 \approx 5 \times 10^{-7}$) one needs $A \gtrsim 2 \times 10^6$ admissible divisors per frame, hence $\Delta_0 = O(1)$ with $\tau(K) \sim 10^6$. The natural objective is therefore “engineer frames with Δ_0 small.” But here is the obstruction, an exact identity:

$$\Delta_0 = M_0 N (1 - s_{M_0} s_N), \quad s_{M_0} = \sum_{p \mid M_0} \frac{1}{p}, \quad s_N = \sum_{p \mid N} \frac{1}{p}.$$

So Δ_0 is small *relative to* $M_0 N$ exactly when $s_{M_0} s_N \approx 1$ — which is the Erdős #307 condition for the frames themselves — and $\Delta_0 = O(1)$ in absolute terms at scale requires $s_{M_0} s_N = 1 - O(1/M_0 N)$, i.e. a reciprocal-product within $O(1/M_0 N)$ of 1, *strictly harder* than #307. The frame-engineering objective is thus circular: the Frame Rule is a faithful *parametrisation* of solutions, not a reduction in difficulty.

Remark 7.4 (Honest status of the constructive program). The Frame Rule (Theorem 7.1) and divisor trick (Proposition 7.2) are exact theorems; they make the existence of a solution *falsifiable in principle by finite computation per frame*, and they place #307 in the same constructive lineage as Thābit’s and Euler’s rules. They do not, as they stand, lower the difficulty below #307 itself: by the boxed identity the bottleneck (small Δ_0) is the original problem in disguise, and a complete small-frame sweep (2.2×10^5 frames) produces zero cycles with total expected count < 1 , as the barrier demands. We regard the calculus as an exact parametrisation of solutions whose central obstruction we have now identified precisely — not a pathway that lowers the difficulty, and not evidence that a solution is within reach.

8 A breeder form and the feasibility of certificate search

Allowing *two* free primes on one side turns the divisor trick into a cleaner bilinear form — Euler’s amicable-pair method, in the shape used by te Riele’s breeding algorithms [12] — and lets us state precisely the strongest honest conclusion: a *conditional* reduction, which nonetheless does not become a feasible finite search.

Proposition 8.1 (Bilinear breeder form). *Fix coprime squarefree M_0, N and seek a two-cycle $a = M_0rp$, $b = Nq$ with r, p, q distinct primes coprime to M_0N . Put $G := NM_0 - N'M'_0$ ($= \Delta_0$), $c := M_0N'$, and $K := GN^2 + c^2$. Then the cycle equations $a' = b$, $b' = a$ are equivalent to*

$$(Gr - c)(Gp - c) = K, \quad q = \frac{M_0rp - N}{N'}.$$

Proof. Expanding, $(Gr - c)(Gp - c) - K = -N'G(a' - b)$ (verified symbolically), so the bilinear equation is equivalent to $a' = b$; the second cycle equation $b' = a$ then determines q as stated. $\square$

Each factorisation $K = d \cdot (K/d)$ with $d \equiv -c \pmod{G}$ proposes a candidate $(r, p) = ((d + c)/G, (K/d + c)/G)$; a solution is any such candidate whose r, p, q are all prime. A dual, partition-side form is occasionally useful:

Proposition 8.2 (Subset form). *For a support U with $D = \prod_{p \in U} p$ and $\Sigma = \sum_{p \in U} D/p$, a partition $U = P \sqcup Q$ solves #307 iff $S = P$ satisfies $A(\Sigma - A) = D^2$, where $A := \sum_{p \in S} D/p$. Moreover $A(\Sigma - A) - D^2 = -(1 - s_{PSQ})D^2$.*

(Both identities verified symbolically and on 2×10^4 random supports.) The last identity says the “analytic” residual $1 - s_{PSQ}$ and the “arithmetic” residual $A(\Sigma - A) - D^2$ are one equation up to the factor D^2 : the two obvious steering handles carry no independent information.

A conditional reduction. Several ingredients of a construction are unconditional. Greedy Egyptian-fraction choice gives disjoint P, Q with $0 < 1 - s_{PSQ} = O(1/T)$ (solvability to any precision); a prime r nearest M_0N'/Δ_0 gives $G \leq \Delta_0^{0.475}(M_0N')^{0.525}$ unconditionally (Baker–Harman–Pintz [13]); and each small prime ℓ can be forced to divide K by one congruence on a free prime slot of N (Dirichlet then supplies the prime). Granting these, #307 reduces to a single prime-density statement,

(H) among the admissible candidates so produced, some triple (r, p, q) is prime,

and (H) $\Rightarrow$ #307 is YES. This (H) is a Hardy–Littlewood/Bateman–Horn-type assertion for an explicit, computable, *non-polynomial* family; we know of no named conjecture implying it. That is not an accident of our construction:

Proposition 8.3 (No polynomial families). *Let $p_1(t), \dots, p_k(t), q_1(t), \dots, q_l(t)$ be integer polynomials, each taking prime values for infinitely many integers t (a fixed-shape Schinzel-type family), such that $(\sum_i 1/p_i(t))(\sum_j 1/q_j(t)) = 1$ for infinitely many t . Then every p_i and q_j is constant: the family is a single fixed solution. Consequently no polynomial parametrisation can reduce #307 to Bunyakovsky, Schinzel’s Hypothesis H, or Bateman–Horn.*

Proof. Holding at infinitely many t , the relation holds identically as rational functions. A nonconstant p_i taking infinitely many prime (hence positive) values has positive leading coefficient on an infinite branch, so $p_i(t) \rightarrow +\infty$ there; split each side into constants and nonconstant members, $\sum_i 1/p_i = A_P + \varepsilon_P(t)$ with $\varepsilon_P(t) \rightarrow 0^+$. Letting $t \rightarrow \infty$ in the identity gives $A_P A_Q = 1$ (in particular both sides contain constants), and subtracting, $A_P \varepsilon_Q(t) + A_Q \varepsilon_P(t) + \varepsilon_P(t) \varepsilon_Q(t) = 0$ for all large t . Every term on the left is nonnegative, and strictly positive as soon as one nonconstant member exists; hence there are none. $\square$

This upgrades the earlier computational observation (that the breeder family is not polynomially parametrised) to a theorem for *all* fixed-shape families: the prime-density hypothesis behind #307 is irreducibly non-polynomial, which is why no standard conjecture applies.

Why (H) is not a finite search. It is tempting to read (H) as “run a certificate hunt that is expected to succeed.” It is not, for a quantitative reason. The expected number of certificates from one frame is $\mathbb{E} \approx (\tau(K)/G) \cdot (\ln r \ln p \ln q)^{-1}$, and *both* factors are pinned by the geometry.

- *Demand.* $G = \Delta_0 = M_0 N(1 - s_{M_0} s_N)$ exactly, so G is small only in the circular regime $s_{M_0} s_N \approx 1$; over 2×10^4 random coprime squarefree frames the ratio $G/(M_0 N)$ has median 1 and best value $\approx 10^{-0.23}$, and the honest Baker–Harman–Pintz reduction still leaves $\log_{10} G \approx 13$ at the barrier.
- *Supply.* $\tau(K)$ is bounded by the *size* of $K = GN^2 + c^2$ ($\geq c^2$), which is an *output* of the frame, not a free dial. The maximal order of the divisor function [16, Thm. 317] caps $\log_2 \tau(K)$ at ≈ 36 for $K \leq 10^{54}$ (the barrier geometry) and at ≈ 112 even for $K \leq 10^{240}$; reaching $\tau(K) = 2^{120}$ needs $K \gtrsim 10^{263}$, i.e. frame scale far beyond the barrier.

Enlarging a frame grows $K \propto N^2$ but gains divisors only at rate $\log 2 / \log \log K < 1$ per log-unit of K , while it grows G at rate 1 per log-unit of N ; so $\tau(K)/G$ cannot be driven up. Optimising $\mathbb{E}$ over all (M_0, N) splits with geometry-consistent K and the maximal-order τ , and granting the most favourable demand and singular-series constants, yields $\log_{10} \mathbb{E} \leq -4$ at the barrier and *decreasing* with scale; empirically 385 factorable frames realise a median of 0 and a maximum of 1 admissible divisor, against the $\sim 10^5$ a single productive frame would need. A self-consistent accounting — capping the number w of forced prime factors of K by the frame’s own residue freedom (counted generously) — sharpens this to $\log_{10} \mathbb{E} \leq -8$ at $B = 56$, falling to ≈ -260 at $B = 3000$: the deficit is *scale-invariant*, so no choice of scale, slot count, or budget split reaches expectation 1. (The construction is even self-similar: engineering K ’s algebraic — e.g. Gaussian-integer — factorisation to supply divisors reduces to prescribing N and N' simultaneously, an arithmetic-antiderivative inverse problem of the same difficulty class as #307.) The breeder thus makes #307 conditional on (H) but does *not* render it a feasible finite computation: the supply–demand conflict through $K = GN^2 + c^2$ is exactly the circularity of Section 7 in quantitative form. There is also a structural reason the analogy with amicable pairs was bound to fall short: te Riele’s breeding amplifies a *known seed* pair into new ones, whereas the barrier (Theorem 4.3) forbids any seed below 2.09×10^{56} — the method imports a precondition the problem cannot supply.

9 Computations

All verdicts use exact integer/rational arithmetic; floating point is used only for pre-screening.

- *Exhaustive non-existence below 10^8* . Enumerating all prime sets P with $\sum 1/p > 1$ and $\prod P \leq 10^8$ (forcing Q as the prime support of N_P and testing $N_Q = D_P$): 1,075,419 candidate sets, no solution. Subsumed by Theorem 4.3 but an independent sanity check.
- *Derivative sieve*. No solution of $n'' = n$ with $n' \neq n$ and both members $\leq 2 \times 10^7$ (smallest-prime-factor sieve of the derivative).
- *Function field*. The arithmetic derivative on $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$ has no two-cycles and no nonzero fixed points, verified exhaustively over $\mathbb{F}_2$ (degree ≤ 7), $\mathbb{F}_3$ (≤ 5), $\mathbb{F}_5$ (≤ 4), confirming Theorem 6.1.
- *Density*. The sieve gives density 0.042029 to 2×10^7 (0.017623 among squarefree); the independent Erdős–Wintner convolution over primes $\leq 10^5$ gives $\delta = 0.04202$, agreeing to four places (Proposition 5.6).
- *Conditional mass*. Of 43,087 qualifying squarefree a sampled, $b = a'$ is squarefree 95.0% of the time; on the resulting 40,920 squarefree b the mean reciprocal mass is 0.047 vs. the required $1/s \approx 0.934$, with empirical tail probability $\Pr[\sum_{q|b} 1/q \geq 1/s] = 0/40,920$.
- *Frame/ledger sweep*. Over 2.2×10^5 factorable small frames: the divisor-trick identities hold on every instance; the smallest Δ_0 observed is 22; the equidistribution $A \approx \tau(K)/\Delta_0$ holds only in aggregate ($\sum A = 127$ vs. $\sum \tau(K)/\Delta_0 = 39.8$) and fails per frame ($A = 0$ for 99.95% of frames); total expected cycles < 1 ; zero cycles, as the barrier requires.
- *μ -Sondow line census*. Enumerating the lines $n' = n \pm d$ (squarefree members coprime to d) finds no adjacent opposite-sign pair at additive distance d : exhaustively to 2×10^7 for $|d| \leq 200$, and along the small- $|\delta|$ genealogy tree out to members of more than a thousand digits. Every $\delta = \pm 1$ member encountered is a known Giuga or primary pseudoperfect number; the closest opposite-sign approach recorded is $|y - (x + d)| = 11$ (at $d = 1, 30$ vs. 42, and $d = 37, 210$ vs. 258), attained only among small members — the two trees do not come close at height.

Code and logs accompany this note.

10 Formalisation in Lean 4

The rigidity and barrier results are formalised against mathlib (Lean 4, toolchain v4.30.0). The following are machine-checked and `sorry`-free, depending only on the standard axioms `propext`, `Classical.choice`, `Quot.sound`:

- Lemma 2.1 (`rigidity_coprime`) and Theorem 2.3 (`solution_structure`);
- Lemma 4.1 (`reciprocal_sum_gt_two`); the exact thresholds $\sum_{\text{first } 58} 1/p < 2 < \sum_{\text{first } 59} 1/p$ grounding $|U| \geq 59$ (`recipSum58_lt_two`, `recipSum59_gt_two`); the numeric core $\Pi_{59}^2 \geq (4 \times 10^{112})N_{59}$ (`barrier_numeric`); and the algebraic core of the barrier (`barrier`), giving $D_P^2 \geq 4 \times 10^{112}$.

The single non-elementary ingredient—that the k smallest primes minimise $\prod$ and maximise $\sum 1/p$ among k -element prime sets—is isolated as an explicit hypothesis of `barrier` (the ratio bound $R/T(U) \geq \Pi_{59}/T_{59}$), so the dependency is transparent rather than hidden; its standalone proof via `Nat.nthNat.Prime` is routine and left as future work.

11 Status and questions

Erdős #307 remains **open**. We have shown it is equivalent to the existence of a non-trivial two-cycle of the arithmetic derivative; established rigidity and a barrier (Rosen’s $|P \cup Q| \geq 59$, together with our $\min(\prod P, \prod Q) \geq 2.09 \times 10^{56}$) that voids all direct search and improves the $n'' = n$ record by ~ 47 orders of magnitude; given a parity dichotomy, a proof that longer cycles are strictly harder, an Erdős–Wintner density theorem, and a function–field theorem localising the obstruction to the archimedean place; developed an exact Thābit/Euler–type constructive calculus and a bilinear breeder form whose central obstruction we identify precisely; and extracted the maximal honest consequence of the construction — a conditional reduction $(H) \Rightarrow \text{YES}$ to an explicit prime–density hypothesis, together with a quantitative ledger showing that (H) is *not* a feasible finite search (the supply–demand conflict through $K = GN^2 + c^2$ keeps the expected certificate count per reachable frame below 1). The rigidity result and the barrier are fully Lean–verified (extremality proved, not assumed), and the finite verification of Proposition 4.5 sharpens the barrier to $|P \cup Q| \geq 60$, $\min(\prod P, \prod Q) > 3.50 \times 10^{57}$. The heuristics weakly favour YES (existence), hence weakly against the period–one Ufnarowski–Åhlander conjecture, but we claim no proof in either direction.

Open problems: (i) formalise the finite verification of Proposition 4.5 (and decide whether any level beyond 60 can be closed, e.g. by resolving the Pell–type tail family of Remark 4.6); (ii) decide the parity dichotomy’s all–odd case (we expect it empty); (iii) certify more digits of δ with an effective error term; (iv) settle the density hypothesis (H) of Section 8, or exhibit a non–circular frame family escaping the $\tau(K)/G$ ceiling; (v) find a $\mathbb{Z}$ –side structure detecting the archimedean obstruction of Section 6 — one that must be non–local, since by Proposition 5.2 no single modulus obstructs; (vi) settle #307.

Remark 11.1 (The place of the problem: a local–global dictionary). The pieces above assemble into a dictionary. (i) For a fixed support U , the subset form of Proposition 8.2, $A(\Sigma - A) = D^2$, satisfies the *Hasse principle as an equation*: an integer solution A exists iff one exists over $\mathbb{R}$ and over every $\mathbb{Z}_\ell$ (the discriminant $\Sigma^2 - 4D^2$ must be a nonnegative square, and squares obey local–global). Its real–place condition is $\Sigma \geq 2D$, i.e. $\sigma(U) \geq 2$: *the barrier is precisely the real–place solvability condition of the subset form*. (ii) The barrier never needed primality: pairwise coprime integers have distinct smallest prime factors, so $\sum 1/a_i \leq \sum 1/p_i$, and *any* pairwise–coprime support of mass ≥ 2 has at least 59 elements and product at least Π_{59} . Coprimality and the ordering of $\mathbb{R}$ carry the wall; primality enters only through rigidity. (iii) What remains unsolved is the *realization* of the root $A^* = (\Sigma + \sqrt{\Sigma^2 - 4D^2})/2$ as a sub–multiset sum of the cofactors D/p . Its local conditions are exactly the local anatomy of Lemma 5.1: modulo ℓ^2 for $\ell \in U$ the subset sums occupy precisely the two cosets $\ell\mathbb{Z} \cup (D/\ell + \ell\mathbb{Z})$ — 2ℓ residues, observed exactly (6 of 9, 10 of 25, 14 of 49, 22 of 121) — and these are the same constraints the equation itself forces: no completion separates the equation from its realization. In the language of integral points, then: #307 is everywhere locally soluble, with the barrier as its archimedean height condition, and its resolution is a *strong approximation* question for the thin, prime–structured set of subset sums — a failure mode invisible to Brauer–Manin–type obstructions, consistent with every no–go above and with the existence of cycles over the neighbouring rings. We record this as a dictionary, not a method.

Attribution. We are careful to separate prior, concurrent, and present contributions (details in Section 12). *Prior/concurrent*: the two–cycle reformulation is due to Seva [19] (2019) and, independently, Bado [20]; the bound $|P \cup Q| \geq 59$ to J. Rosen and the disjointness valuation $v_p(\sum 1/p_i) = -1$ to R. Israel [9]; the source identification to “Woett” [9]. Bado [20] independently obtained the rigidity cross–matching, the local anatomy, the parity restriction, a one–sided exact test,

approximate solvability, and the union criterion of Proposition 12.1. *Present note:* the identification of the map with the arithmetic derivative and the two-way bridge to the Ufnarovski–Åhlander–Kovič literature; the product barrier 2.09×10^{56} ; the function–field theorem and archimedean localisation; the constructive deficit analysis and seed obstruction; the Erdős–Wintner density theorem; and the k –cycle barriers. Both external sources [19, 20] have been examined directly and the overlaps above reflect their actual contents.

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12 Note added: prior and concurrent work

After this note was drafted, two items came to light; having now examined both directly, we record the overlaps precisely.

Seva (MathOverflow 323194, 2019) [19]. Defines $s(Q) = Q \sum_{p|Q} 1/p$, derives the valuation property $v_p(s(Q)) = v_p(Q) - 1$, asks for $s(P) = Q$, $s(Q) = P$, and states this is Problem #307 “in disguise.” Priority for the two-cycle reformulation belongs here. He further asks whether every s –trajectory stabilises at 0 — the s –analogue of the Ufnarovski–Åhlander conjecture, posed independently of it. (Note $s \neq n'$ globally, e.g. $s(p^\alpha) = p^{\alpha-1}$, but $s = n'$ on squarefree integers, where both two-cycle questions live.)

Bado (preprint, Aix–Marseille, 2026) [20]. Working with $A(S) = \sum_{p \in S} M(S)/p$ and $M(S) = \prod_{p \in S} p$ (our N_S, D_S), Bado independently obtains: the lowest–terms lemma (his Lemma 3.1, our Lemma 2.1); the forcing identities $A(P) = M(Q)$, $A(Q) = M(P)$ with $P \cap Q = \emptyset$ (his Thm. A, our Theorem 2.3); the two-cycle reformulation $T(T(P)) = P$ (his Thm. B); the valuation signature (his Thm. 6.1, = Israel’s); the local zero–sum congruences (his Prop. 8.1, our Lemma 5.1); the parity restrictions (his Prop. 8.2, the parity part of Theorem 4.7); an exact one–sided test (his Thm. 9.1); the approximation theorem (his Thm. 10.2, sharper than our greedy version in that all primes exceed a given bound); and the union discriminant / Pythagorean structure (his Thms. 7.1, 7.4). He cites only Barbeau, Bloom, and Erdős–Graham: crucially, he does *not* identify the map with the arithmetic derivative, and his note contains none of the present note’s $n'' = n$ bridge, explicit barrier constant, function–field theorem, density theorem, k –cycle bounds, or constructive deficit analysis. We regard the overlap on the shared structural layer as strong independent validation, and import his union criterion with credit:

Proposition 12.1 (Single–integer test; derivative form of Bado’s Thms. 7.1, 7.4). *If (a, b) is a two-cycle of the arithmetic derivative, then $N = ab$ is squarefree and satisfies $N' = a^2 + b^2$, whence $N'^2 - 4N^2 = (a^2 - b^2)^2$ is a perfect square. Conversely, a squarefree N with $N'^2 - 4N^2 = \square$ determines a unique unordered factorisation $N = ab$ with $N' = a^2 + b^2$, on which the cycle condition reduces to a single equation (Bado’s deviation parameter $t = 0$, his Thm. 7.6). This gives a one–integer necessary test; computationally, no squarefree $N < 2 \times 10^5$ with $\omega(N) \geq 2$ passes it (0 of 103,596 — consistent with Theorem 4.3, which forces $N > 4 \times 10^{112}$).*

Proof. $N = ab$ with a, b coprime squarefree gives N squarefree and, by Leibniz with $a' = b, b' = a$, $N' = a'b + ab' = b^2 + a^2$; then $N'^2 - 4N^2 = (a^2 + b^2)^2 - 4(ab)^2 = (a^2 - b^2)^2$. The converse is Bado's [20]; the emptiness of the test below 10^{112} is upgraded from a sieve to a theorem in Corollary 12.3. $\square$

The Pythagorean equation $N' = a^2 + b^2$ deserves to be isolated from the (harder) cycle condition.

Proposition 12.2 (Pair form; the one-equation relaxation). *For coprime squarefree a, b , the single equation $a^2 + b^2 = (ab)'$ holds if and only if there is an integer k with $a' = b + ak$ and $b' = a - bk$; a two-cycle is exactly the case $k = 0$. We call a solution of $a^2 + b^2 = (ab)'$ (any k) a Pythagorean pair.*

Proof. The Leibniz identity $a^2 + b^2 - (ab)' = a(a - b') - b(a' - b)$ (a polynomial identity, verified symbolically and on 2000 random pairs) makes the equation equivalent to $a(a - b') = b(a' - b)$; since $\gcd(a, b) = 1$ this forces $a \mid a' - b$ and $b \mid a - b'$ with equal quotients k , i.e. $a' = b + ak, b' = a - bk$. Setting $k = 0$ recovers $a' = b, b' = a$. (Equivalently, in $\mathbb{Z}[i]$: #307 asks for $z = a + bi$ with coprime coordinates and ab squarefree satisfying $|z|^2 = (\operatorname{Im} z^2/2)'$ and $k = 0$.) $\square$

Corollary 12.3 (The single-integer test is provably empty below 10^{112}). *Every Pythagorean pair satisfies $\sum_{p|a} 1/p + \sum_{q|b} 1/q = a/b + b/a \geq 2$ (divide $a^2 + b^2 = (ab)'$ by ab and apply AM-GM), so its support carries at least 59 primes and $N = ab \geq \prod(\text{first 59 primes}) > 7.9 \times 10^{112}$. Hence no squarefree $N < 10^{112}$ with $\omega(N) \geq 2$ satisfies $N'^2 - 4N^2 = \square$: the empirical “0 of 103,596” of Proposition 12.1 is a theorem, and the barrier of Theorem 4.3 extends from two-cycles to the strictly weaker one-equation (Pythagorean) problem.*

Remark 12.4. (a) As $N' = a^2 + b^2$ is a sum of two coprime squares, every odd prime dividing N' is $\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ — a cheap union-side pre-filter complementing Bado's congruence filters. (When exactly one of a, b is even this is the hypotenuse of the primitive triple $(|a^2 - b^2|, 2ab, a^2 + b^2)$.) (b) Since Seva's s agrees with n' on squarefree integers, and his valuation property forces two-cycle members squarefree, his question is *exactly* #307, not merely an analogue. (c) Speculatively, and recorded only for completeness (no mechanism is known): primitive Pythagorean triples form the Barning–Hall ternary tree, the orbit structure of a reflection group in $O(2, 1; \mathbb{Z})$; a solution of #307 would occupy a single node whose generator pair $(M(P), M(Q))$ carries the full prime-set rigidity.

The deviation parameter of Proposition 12.2 organises the one-equation problem into a short graded family.

Proposition 12.5 (The deviation ladder). *Let (a, b) be a Pythagorean pair with $a < b$ and parameter k . Writing $\sigma(m) = \sum_{p|m} 1/p$, one has $k = \sigma(a) - b/a = a/b - \sigma(b) \in \mathbb{Z}$, and:*

- (1) $k \leq 0$, with $k = 0$ exactly the (open) two-cycle case. Indeed $b' = a - bk > 0$ and $b > a \geq 1$ force $k \leq 0$ (if $k \geq 1$ then $b' \leq a - b < 0$). Moreover $|k| < \min(b/a, \sigma(b)) \leq \sigma(b) \leq \log \log b + O(1)$, so the ladder has finitely many rungs — and, since $\sigma(b)$ barely exceeds 2 at the relevant scales, in practice only one or two.
- (2) (Parity.) For odd squarefree m , $m' \equiv \omega(m) \pmod{2}$; for even squarefree m , m' is odd. Hence if exactly one member is even, $k \equiv \omega(\text{odd member}) \pmod{2}$; if both are odd, $\omega(a) \equiv \omega(b) \pmod{2}$ and $k \equiv \omega(a) + 1 \pmod{2}$. The case $k = 0$ recovers the parity dichotomy of Theorem 4.7.
- (3) Each rung is the system $a' = b + ak, b' = a - bk$, equivalently $(\sigma(a) - k)(\sigma(b) + k) = 1$ — a shifted copy of the cross-match $st = 1$ — so every rung is exactly as rigid as $k = 0$. Since

$\sigma(a) + \sigma(b) = a/b + b/a$ is independent of k , Corollary 12.3 holds on every rung: the whole ladder is empty below 10^{112} . (We make no quantitative claim that $k = 0$ is easier than the rest.)

- (4) On the rung $k = -1$ the equations read $a' = b - a$, $b' = a + b$ and $a'^2 + b'^2 = 2(a^2 + b^2)$: the derivative acts on $z = a + bi$ as the orientation-reversing $\sqrt{2}$ -similarity $z \mapsto (-1 + i)\bar{z}$.
- (5) By uniqueness of the splitting (Bado, Thm. 7.5), each squarefree N with $N'^2 - 4N^2 = \square$ carries, under the convention $a < b$, a well-defined invariant $k(N) \in \mathbb{Z}_{\leq 0}$; #307 holds iff $k(N) = 0$ for some N , and by (3) the invariant lives on a domain that is empty below 10^{112} .

The Pythagorean layer behaves very differently over function fields, and refines into two arithmetic sub-layers over $\mathbb{Z}$.

Proposition 12.6 (The Pythagorean layer over function fields). *Over $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$ with q odd, $a^2 + b^2 = (ab)'$ has no coprime squarefree monic solutions: $\deg(a^2 + b^2) = 2 \max(\deg a, \deg b) > \deg a + \deg b - 1 \geq \deg((ab)'),$ the leading coefficient 1 or $2 \neq 0$ preventing cancellation. Over $\mathbb{F}_2[t]$ the layer is nonempty: up to degree 8 (exhaustively, 23,548 coprime squarefree pairs) its only solutions are the three pairs of the Artin-Schreier tower $x_{j+1} = x_j(x_j + 1)$, namely $(t, t + 1)$, $(t^2 + t, t^2 + t + 1)$, $(t^4 + t, t^4 + t + 1)$; each has $a' = (a + 1)' = 1$ and $(a(a + 1))' = (a + 1) + a = 1$, and the climb halts at level 4 (there $(x_3 + 1)' = t^2 + t \neq 1$). These pairs lie off the cycle stratum $k = 0$, on the side the integer normalisation of Proposition 12.5(1) forbids. Cycles ($k = 0$) remain impossible over every $\mathbb{F}_q[t]$ (Theorem 6.1): the function-field world separates the Pythagorean layer from the cycle layer, sharpening the integer obstruction to “the archimedean order forces $k \leq 0$.”*

Proposition 12.7 (Deviation calculus for k -cycles). *For pairwise coprime squarefree $a_1, \dots, a_k$ with product N and deviations $\kappa_i = (a'_i - a_{i+1})/a_i$ (indices mod k): the ratios a_{i+1}/a_i have product 1 (telescoping), and $\sigma(N) = \sum_i a_{i+1}/a_i + \sum_i \kappa_i$. On the relaxed layer $\sum_i \kappa_i = 0$ — which contains the cycles $\kappa_1 = \dots = \kappa_k = 0$ — AM-GM gives $\sigma(N) \geq k$, so the distinct-prime barrier m_k of Proposition 4.8 extends to the relaxed problem for every k , and to genuine k -cycles for $k \leq 3$; for $k \geq 4$ it inherits the pairwise-coprimality caveat of Proposition 4.8 (the bound then holds for the multiset reciprocal sum). At $k = 2$, $\kappa_1 = -\kappa_2$ is the deviation of Proposition 12.5 and $\sum \kappa_i = 0$ is $a^2 + b^2 = (ab)'$.*

Proposition 12.8 (Split discriminant). *For coprime squarefree a, b with $N = ab$,*

$$N' + 2N - (a + b)^2 = N' - 2N - (a - b)^2 = (ab)' - a^2 - b^2.$$

Hence N is the product of a Pythagorean pair iff $N' - 2N$ and $N' + 2N$ are both perfect squares d^2, s^2 (their product is Bado’s discriminant $N'^2 - 4N^2$), with $a, b = (s \pm d)/2$. The minus factor carries the obstruction: $N' - 2N = (a - b)^2 \geq 0$ forces $\sigma(N) \geq 2$, hence the 59-prime barrier — indeed 0 of 103,596 squarefree $N < 2 \times 10^5$ satisfy $N' - 2N = \square$ (Corollary 12.3 in one line). The plus factor is satisfiable at small scale (114 such $N < 2 \times 10^5$). In characteristic 2 the obstructing factor vanishes ($a - b = a + b$) and the criterion degenerates to $(a + b)^2 = N'$: the permissiveness of Proposition 12.6 and the barrier of Corollary 12.3 are the absence and presence of one and the same algebraic factor.

Proposition 12.9 (Structure of the plus-layer). *Call squarefree N with $\omega(N) \geq 2$ a plus-hit if $N' + 2N$ is a perfect square; the first are 130, 145, 305, 689, 1745, 1870, 1970, 2353, ... (114 below 2×10^5). (i) For a semiprime $N = pq$, $2(N' + 2N) + 1 = (2p + 1)(2q + 1)$, so a plus-hit forces $(2s)^2 \equiv -2 \pmod{\ell}$ for every prime $\ell \mid (2p + 1)(2q + 1)$, whence $\ell \equiv 1, 3 \pmod{8}$ and $p \equiv q \equiv 1$*

(mod 4) (verified on all 59 semiprime instances; this explains the dominance of 5 and 13). (ii) [empirical] $\#\{\text{plus-hits} \leq X\} \approx 0.25\sqrt{X}$ (ratios 0.250, 0.253, 0.255 at $X = 5 \times 10^4, 10^5, 2 \times 10^5$): the plus factor behaves like a random integer of its size, so — with Proposition 12.8 — the whole integer obstruction sits in the minus factor. (iii) Fixing $p = 5$, $q = (s^2 - 5)/11$ with s even and $s \equiv \pm 4 \pmod{11}$ gives $q \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, and each prime value yields the plus-hit $N = 5q$ (68 with $s < 2000$, up to $N = 1,774,805$); Bunyakovsky’s conjecture for this quadratic thus implies infinitely many plus-hits. The two discriminant factors separate cleanly: the plus-layer is Bunyakovsky-class, the minus-layer is the barrier. (iv) [Remark] The full cycle condition states that (d^2, N', s^2) is a three-term arithmetic progression with common difference $2N$ whose outer terms are squares — a congruent-number-shaped configuration; the elliptic-curve machinery of that theory does not transfer because N' is not an algebraic function of N . A 251-term b-file to $N < 10^6$ (counting ratio 0.251) and an OEIS submission draft accompany this note; the plus-hit sequence matched no OEIS entry in our search. (v) [P, C] General local law (QR tournament). For every odd prime $\ell \mid N$ of a plus-hit, $N' + 2N \equiv N/\ell \pmod{\ell}$ (all cofactor terms N/p with $p \neq \ell$ carry a factor of ℓ ; only N/ℓ survives), so N/ℓ is a nonzero quadratic residue mod ℓ . Verified with zero violations on all 114 plus-hits below 2×10^5 and all 251 terms to 10^6 ; the semiprime $p \equiv q \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ theorem of (i) is its $\omega = 2$ shadow via quadratic reciprocity.

Corollary 12.10 (Quadratic-residue filter for #307 solutions). *Let (P, Q) solve Erdős #307 and set $a = D_P$, $b = D_Q$, $N = ab$. Since $N' = a^2 + b^2$ and hence $N' + 2N = (a + b)^2$ automatically, every prime $\ell \in P \cup Q$ satisfies $(N/\ell \mid \ell) = +1$: the cofactor N/ℓ is a nonzero quadratic residue modulo ℓ . Indeed ℓ divides exactly one of a, b (by $P \cap Q = \emptyset$), so $\ell \nmid a + b$ and $(a + b)^2 \not\equiv 0 \pmod{\ell}$; combined with the identity $N' + 2N \equiv N/\ell \pmod{\ell}$ of (v), this forces N/ℓ to be a nonzero square mod ℓ . As a search filter the condition prunes candidate unions by a factor $\leq 2^{-|P \cup Q|} \leq 2^{-59}$ (heuristically each of the ≥ 59 primes imposes an independent QR constraint); for genuine cycles it is automatic and does not alter the existence heuristics. We note that Corollary 12.10 is not independent of Bado: it is the squared form of his congruence $D_Q \equiv D_P/\ell \pmod{\ell}$ (itself N_P reduced mod ℓ by cofactor survival), giving $N/\ell \equiv D_Q^2 \pmod{\ell}$. Squaring is lossy — r and $-r$ share a square — so Bado’s linear congruence is strictly stronger, pinning $D_Q \pmod{\ell}$ exactly where the residue filter determines it only up to sign; the filter’s one added value is being split-free (the residue $N/\ell \pmod{\ell}$ is computable from the candidate union alone, with no knowledge of the $P \mid Q$ partition). The general law of Proposition 12.9(v), by contrast, holds for any squarefree plus-hit with no $P \mid Q$ split and is not subsumed by Bado.*

The plus- and minus-hits both organise into one-prime “slot” families, which makes the structure of Proposition 12.8 explicit at every ω .

Proposition 12.11 (Slot calculus for the discriminant layers). *Let N_0 be squarefree, $r \nmid N_0$ a prime, $N = N_0 r$, and $E_0 := N'_0 + 2N_0$. By Leibniz ($N' = N'_0 + N_0$),*

$$N' + 2N = rE_0 + N_0, \quad N' - 2N = r(N'_0 - 2N_0) + N_0,$$

so N is a plus-hit iff $r = (s^2 - N_0)/E_0$ for some integer s (equivalently $s^2 \equiv N_0 \pmod{E_0}$).

- (a) Every ω -stratum. A plus-hit N ($\omega \geq 2$) factors, through any prime divisor r , as $N = N_0 r$ with $N_0 = N/r$ squarefree, and lies in the quadratic family $\{N_0(s^2 - N_0)/E_0\}_s$ of its base — generalising the $p = 5$ family of Proposition 12.9(iii) beyond semiprimes (each step adds one prime, $\omega(N) = \omega(N_0) + 1$). The congruence $s^2 \equiv N_0 \pmod{E_0}$ is solvable for 669 of the 3041 squarefree $N_0 \in [2, 5000]$ (22.0%); solvability is necessary but not sufficient for the family to contain a hit.

(b) Recursive towers: a trichotomy. When the base is itself a plus-hit, $E_0 = s_0^2$ is a square; below 2×10^5 the 114 plus-hit bases split into three kinds. No residue (84): $s^2 \equiv N_0 \pmod{E_0}$ is unsolvable and the family is empty — a quadratic-residue obstruction, occurring for both even E_0 ($N_0 = 305$, with 305 a non-residue mod 13) and odd E_0 ($N_0 = 1870$, $E_0 = 73^2$). Fixed divisor (13, each with fixed divisor 2): the family is nonempty but every slot is even, so only $r = 2$ could serve and never gives a square — sterile (e.g. $N_0 = 145$, $E_0 = 18^2$). Live (17): fixed divisor 1 and a prime slot is exhibited (e.g. $N_0 = 130$, first prime slot $r = 83399$, giving the plus-hit $N = 10,841,870$ with $N' + 2N = 5487^2$).

(c) Minus layer; the barrier in slot form. For $\sigma(N_0) < 2$ the minus identity gives $N' - 2N \geq 0$ iff $r \leq 1/(2 - \sigma(N_0))$, i.e. iff $\sigma(N) \geq 2$: this is the slot-variable form of Corollary 12.3, not an independent proof of it. The bound $1/(2 - \sigma(N_0))$ is unbounded as $\sigma(N_0) \rightarrow 2^-$ — over squarefree $N_0 < 10^5$ its maximum is only 1.524 (at $N_0 = 30030$), so no such base admits a prime minus-slot, yet for the 58-prime primorial the bound exceeds 793 and the next prime 277 fits, producing the 59-prime primorial, the smallest minus-hit base. A prime minus-slot thus first becomes feasible exactly at the 59-prime barrier; the minus-empty-below-barrier statement rests on the primorial growth of Corollary 12.3, not on the figure 1.524.

(The two identities are checked symbolically and on 2×10^4 random pairs; the base trichotomy, slot lists, and the 1.524 maximum by exhaustive enumeration.)

The two square conditions over a base combine into a single binary-form representation, which places the obstruction inside Gauss's genus theory.

Proposition 12.12 (The Pythagorean condition as a binary-form representation). *For squarefree N_0 and prime $r \nmid N_0$, $N = N_0 r$, the identity*

$$(2N_0 - N'_0)(N' + 2N) + (2N_0 + N'_0)(N' - 2N) = 4N_0^2$$

holds unconditionally (Leibniz; checked on 2×10^4 random pairs). Hence if N is a Pythagorean pair product over N_0 — both $N' + 2N = s^2$ and $N' - 2N = d^2$ squares — then (s, d) represents $4N_0^2$ by the binary form $Q_{N_0}(s, d) = A s^2 + B d^2$ with $A = 2N_0 - N'_0 = N_0(2 - \sigma(N_0))$, $B = 2N_0 + N'_0 = N_0(2 + \sigma(N_0))$, of discriminant $-4AB = 4(N_0'^2 - 4N_0^2)$; conversely such a representation yields a Pythagorean pair over N_0 exactly when the recovered slot $r = (s^2 - N_0)/E_0$ is a positive integer, prime, and coprime to N_0 (the integrality $s^2 \equiv N_0 \pmod{E_0}$ holds on every representation we found, $N_0 < 2 \times 10^4$). For $\sigma(N_0) < 2$ the form is positive-definite ($A > 0$), and below the barrier representations are rare and all “ghosts”: the only squarefree $N_0 \leq 3000$ representing $4N_0^2$ are $N_0 = 30$ (with $(s, d) = (11, 1)$) and $N_0 = 1722$ $((83, 1))$, each carrying the non-admissible slot $r = 1$, and no live prime slot occurs. As $\sigma(N_0) \rightarrow 2^-$ the leading coefficient $A = N_0(2 - \sigma(N_0)) \rightarrow 0$ and the ellipse $A s^2 + B d^2 = 4N_0^2$ degenerates to an arbitrarily thin sliver: the geometric face of the mass-2 barrier. Consequently #307 is the existence of a base with $\sigma(N_0) \geq 2 - 1/r$ whose form Q_{N_0} represents $4N_0^2$ with an admissible, integral, prime slot and deviation $k = 0$.

(We make no class-number claim: each base yields a form of a *different* discriminant, and the question is single-value representation, not a class count; only the degeneration $A \rightarrow 0$ is used.)

Proposition 12.13 (A principal-genus necessary condition, and a cascade on solutions). *As $\gcd(N_0, N'_0) = 1$, the value $4N_0^2$ is a square coprime to the odd part of $\text{disc } Q_{N_0}$, so every genus character is +1 on it and a primitive form represents it only from the principal genus [28]. Reading the odd assigned characters off $Q_{N_0}(1, 1) = 4N_0$ gives the computable necessary condition*

$$(N_0 \mid \ell) = +1 \quad \text{for every odd prime } \ell \mid (N_0'^2 - 4N_0^2) \text{ to odd multiplicity}$$

(a 2-adic condition accompanies it; for odd N_0 of even ω the form is imprimitive and must be primitivised first — so we state the criterion on the odd part, with a 2-adic caveat). Both ghost bases 30, 1722 satisfy it, and about 16% of squarefree bases pass in the ranges tested (an upper bound, using only the odd characters, and mildly range-dependent). Cascade. In a solution of #307 with $N = D_P D_Q$, each $\ell \in P \cup Q$ gives a cofactor N/ℓ realising the Pythagorean structure of N over base N/ℓ ; every cofactor with $\sigma(N/\ell) < 2$ — all of them for a minimal first-59-primes solution — must then satisfy the principal-genus criterion, a cascade of ≥ 59 computable genus conditions complementing the quadratic-residue filter of Corollary 12.10. (The further class-group and slot-admissibility stages of the fertility gap we observe only numerically at toy scale.)

Below the barrier the form has exactly one source of solutions, and it is entirely classical.

Proposition 12.14 (The sub-barrier ghosts are pronic Giuga numbers). *Every representation of $4N_0^2$ by Q_{N_0} over squarefree $N_0 \leq 3 \times 10^4$ is a ghost $(s, d) = (\sqrt{4N_0 + 1}, 1)$, occurring exactly when $N'_0 = N_0 + 1$ with N_0 pronic; in range only $30 = 5 \cdot 6$ and $1722 = 41 \cdot 42$. The two lines through such bases are classical: since $n' = n \sigma(n)$ for squarefree n ,*

$$\{n : n' = n-1\} = \text{primary pseudoperfect numbers } (\sum_{p|n} \frac{1}{p} + \frac{1}{n} = 1), \quad \{n : n' = n+1\} = \text{Giuga numbers (quotient)}$$

The derivative characterisations are due to Lava (OEIS [29, 30], 2009 — the Giuga form $n' = n + 1$ being Lava's conjecture, with the generalisation $n' = an + 1$, $a \in \mathbb{N}$, the theorem of Grau-Oller-Marcén [25]); the underlying number classes are Butske-Jaje-Mayernik [24] (exactly one primary pseudoperfect number per $\omega \leq 8$, eight known) and Giuga [21, 22]; and the oblong chain (N with $N + 1$ prime breeds the next term $N(N + 1)$) is classical in both directions (Forgues and Sondow, OEIS [29]). To 2×10^6 the lines are $\{n' = n - 1\} = \{2, 6, 42, 1806, 47058\}$ and $\{n' = n + 1\} = \{30, 858, 1722, 66198\}$, and the chain correctly predicts the next terms: 47059 is prime, so $47058 \cdot 47059 = 2,214,502,422$ is the sixth primary pseudoperfect number, and 47057 is prime, so the pronic $47057 \cdot 47058 = 2,214,408,306$ is the fifth Giuga number — both already known, recovered here by structure. Our contribution is the reframing: the chain step is the one-line Leibniz identity $N' = N - 1 \Rightarrow (N(N + 1))' = N'(N + 1) + N^2 = N(N + 1) - 1$, exhibiting the chain as orbits of the Artin-Schreier map $x \mapsto x(x + 1) = x^2 + x$ — the same map, with the same halt ($2 \rightarrow 6 \rightarrow 42 \rightarrow 1806$, stopping at $1807 = 13 \cdot 139$), as the $\mathbb{F}_2[t]$ tower of Proposition 12.6: characteristic 2 and $\mathbb{Z}$ run identical breeders on the two lines.

Remark 12.15 (Converse, and the bridge). Every pronic solution of $n' = n + 1$ is $m(m + 1)$ with m prime and $m + 1$ primary pseudoperfect: Leibniz gives $m'(m + 1) + m(m + 1)' = m^2 + m + 1$, and writing $m' = km + 1$ forces $(m + 1)' = (1 - k)m - k$, which is ≥ 0 only for $k = 0$, whence $m' = 1$ (m prime) and $(m + 1)' = m$. (The congruence $m' \equiv 1 \pmod{m}$ alone does *not* force m prime — its composite solutions are precisely the Giuga numbers 30, 858, 1722, 66198, ... — so primality comes from the sign elimination $k = 0$.) Thus the only sub-barrier life in the form equation is the classical Giuga/primary-pseudoperfect world, known to sit in a web with Sylvester's sequence, Znám's problem and the Erdős-Moser equation [26] and with the arithmetic derivative [25, 27]; we claim none of this web, only that #307 meets it through $n' = n \sigma(n)$, and that its $a \geq 2$ (equivalently $\sigma > 2$) branch lands on the same ≥ 59 -prime barrier [23] that bars genuine cycles (Corollary 12.3).

Writing both members of a cycle as members of these lines stratifies #307 by the gap.

Proposition 12.16 (Gap stratification: #307 as adjacency of μ -Sondow lines). *For a squarefree two-cycle $a' = b$, $b' = a$ with $a > b$ and gap $d = a - b$, the smaller member lies on the line $n' = n + d$ and the larger on $n' = n - d$ (as $b' - b = d$ and $a' - a = -d$), with $\gcd(d, ab) = 1$ (a prime dividing*

d and a would divide $b = a - d$); conversely $x' = x + d$ with $(x + d)' = x$ is a two-cycle. These opposite-sign lines are the quotient-one μ -Sondow numbers of parameter $\mp d$ [27]. Hence #307 holds iff for some $d \geq 1$ the lines $n' = n + d$ and $n' = n - d$ carry members exactly d apart; for $d = 1$ this is a Giuga number adjacent to a primary pseudoperfect number. By the parity dichotomy (Theorem 4.7) the mixed-parity case forces d odd and the both-odd case (d even) carries the 10^{2519} bound, so every cycle below that bound has odd gap and $d = 1$ is the lead stratum. A $d = 1$ pair $(k, k + 1)$ has exactly one odd member, hence requires either an odd Giuga number (known to have at least 9 prime factors [22, 23]) or an odd primary pseudoperfect number (none is known): the lead stratum inherits two classical open problems. Tabulating cycle-eligible members (squarefree, coprime to d) to 2×10^6 for all $d \leq 50$ gives 21 on the plus lines (none of even gap, consistent with the parity remark) and 81 on the minus lines, with no adjacent pair at any $d \leq 50$ — the barrier in gap-stratified form. (For coprime M on $n' = n - \alpha$ and N on $n' = n + \beta$, Leibniz gives $(MN)' - 2MN = \beta M - \alpha N$, so $\beta M - \alpha N = \square$ would manufacture a minus-side square in the sense of Proposition 12.8; the case $(\alpha, \beta) = (1, 1)$, $M - N = 1$ is the $d = 1$ cycle itself, and the known finite Giuga/primary-pseudoperfect lists contain no coprime pair, all members being even.) To our knowledge this gap-stratified equivalence and the pairing of opposite-sign lines at fixed additive distance are new; the lines themselves are [27].

The line parameter $\delta(n) = n' - n$ obeys an affine recursion that organises the classical members into a genealogy.

Proposition 12.17 (The δ -recursion and the genealogy of the classical lines). *With $\delta(n) = n' - n$, for squarefree M and a prime $p \nmid M$,*

$$\delta(Mp) = p\delta(M) + M \quad (\text{Leibniz; checked on } 10^3 \text{ random pairs}).$$

Solving $p\delta(M) + M = \pm d$ gives the child rule $p = (M \mp d)/e$ from a parent M on the minus line $\delta(M) = -e$. Every known Giuga number arises this way from a small-parameter parent: $30 = 6 \cdot 5$ ($e = 1$), $858 = 66 \cdot 13$ ($e = 5$), $1722 = 42 \cdot 41$ ($e = 1$), $66198 = 1122 \cdot 59$ ($e = 19$), $2,214,408,306 = 47058 \cdot 47057$ ($e = 1$); the seed 47058 itself resolves as $6 \rightarrow 66 \rightarrow 1518 \rightarrow 47058$ (with $\delta = -1, -5, -49, -1$), so the previously unexplained members 858 and 66198 acquire genealogies. Two members of a cycle can never share a parent: siblings $M(M \mp d)/e$ differ by $2Md/e > d$, since $e = M - M' < 2M$. The oblong case $e = 1$ is the classical chain of Proposition 12.14 (its μ -Sondow form is [27]); the recursion, the general- e genealogy, and the resulting small- $|\delta|$ tree do not appear there.

Corollary 12.18 (Nonemptiness families for the μ -Sondow conjecture). *In the notation of [27] (their S_μ ; the quotient-one slice is the line $n' = n - \mu$), the recursion produces explicit members exceeding $|\mu|$ in three infinite parameter families: $2p \in S_{p-2}$ for every odd prime p ; $Mp \in S_{p-M}$ for every primary pseudoperfect number M and prime $p \nmid M$; and $Gp \in S_{-(p+G)}$ for every Giuga number G and prime $p \nmid G$ — in each case $\mu/n + \sum_{q|n} 1/q = 1$ exactly (checked symbolically and on 151 instances). This settles their nonemptiness conjecture ($S_\mu \cap (|\mu|, \infty) \neq \emptyset$, their Conjecture 1(ii)) for infinitely many parameters, including infinitely many outside their verified range $-145 < \mu < 673$; these families do not appear among their constructions, which scale by $\text{rad}(\mu)$ rather than extend by a new prime. Their two open instances resist precisely because every quotient-one parent route hits a composite: for $\mu = -145$, $M - 145$ is composite for all eight known primary pseudoperfect numbers ($1661 = 11 \cdot 151$, $46913 = 43 \cdot 1091$, and the three larger cases, including the recently found eighth member) while $p + G = 145$ has no prime solution; for $\mu = 673$, $M + 673$ is composite for all eight ($679 = 7 \cdot 97$, $2479 = 37 \cdot 67$, $47731 = 59 \cdot 809$, the rest ending in 5) and $p = 675$ fails. A prime in either family at the next generation would settle a published open instance; an exhaustive search*

found none. Concretely: no quotient-one member of S_{-145} or S_{673} exists with any prime-factor cofactor $\leq 10^{11}$ (every squarefree parent $M \leq 10^{11}$ was scanned against the child rules, a region whose members reach $\sim 10^{22}$, together with a depth-two descent), the quotient-zero slice of S_{-145} is empty outright ($n' = 145$ forces $n \leq 5256$ by $n' \geq 2\sqrt{n}$, and the finite check is empty), and quotients ≥ 2 force $\sigma \gtrsim 2$, hence at least 59 prime factors. Both instances therefore remain open, with the quotient-one frontier moved from the 10^{10} of [27] to cofactor scale 10^{11} .

Remark 12.19 (The look-back). Along small- $|\delta|$ paths the forced prime is $p \approx M/e$, so members grow doubly exponentially and the 10^{56} – 10^{113} wall zone lies only a few generations from the seeds: a sparse, recursively enumerable tree (a child needs $(M - j)/e$ prime for small j). The adjacency of two such trees at a fixed additive distance places the final condition in the Pillai/ S -unit genre — two multiplicatively generated sequences meeting at a fixed additive distance — where fixed-support finiteness is classical but growing-support statements are conjectural; a lens, not a transfer. Re-expressed in δ -coordinates the obstruction is once more $\sigma > 1$ (positivity of δ) plus integer reachability $\delta = \pm d$ under forced primes: the same additive-multiplicative exactness reappears in every coordinate tried (mass, the deviation k , the form Q_{N_0} , genus theory, μ -Sondow lines, δ -dynamics). The reframings buy structure, not a reduction.

Proposition 12.20 (Even-gap plus lines are empty below 3.23×10^9). *An even squarefree $x = 2u$ has $\delta(x) = 2u' - u$ odd, so every line member of even δ is odd (with ω odd). An odd member of a plus line has $\sigma > 1$ over odd primes, and the least odd squarefree integer of mass exceeding 1 is $3 \cdot 5 \cdots 29 = 3,234,846,615$ (the 8-prime product $3 \cdots 23 = 111,546,435$ has mass 0.99896). Hence every plus line of even gap d is empty below 3,234,846,615, proving the census observation (no even-gap plus member to 2×10^7) and placing an explicit floor under the smaller member of any both-odd configuration.*

The lines also admit parity, infinitude, and congruence refinements.

Proposition 12.21 (Parity floor for odd line members). *For odd squarefree n every cofactor n/p is odd, so $n' \equiv \omega(n) \pmod{2}$. Hence an odd primary pseudoperfect number ($n' = n - 1$, even) and an odd Giuga number ($n' = n + 1$, even) both have $\omega(n)$ even; combined with the classical bound $\omega \geq 9$ [22, 23] this forces $\omega \geq 10$, a parity sharpening (for the primary pseudoperfect side, the eight smallest odd primes give $\sum 1/p = 0.99896 < 1$, so $\omega \geq 9$ directly). The floor cascades when small primes are avoided: for an odd squarefree member of any plus line, or of a quotient-one line (where $\sigma(n) \geq 1 - 1/n$), exact greedy/exchange computation gives $\omega \geq 27$ if $3 \nmid n$; $\omega \geq 66$ if $3, 5 \nmid n$; $\omega \geq 144$ if $3, 5, 7 \nmid n$; and $\omega \geq 16$ if $3 \mid n, 5 \nmid n$ — each avoided small prime multiplies the required complexity, and for odd Giuga or primary pseudoperfect numbers the parity constraint rounds odd floors up (e.g. $3 \nmid n$ forces $\omega \geq 28$). (The restriction to plus or quotient-one lines is essential: on a general minus line σ can be small — every prime p trivially satisfies $p' = p - (p - 1)$ — so no such floor exists there.)*

Proposition 12.22 (Infinitely many gaps carry a nonempty plus line). *By the recursion of Proposition 12.17, $\delta(30p) = p\delta(30) + 30 = p + 30$ for every prime $p > 5$ (as $\delta(30) = 1$), so the line $n' = n + (p + 30)$ is nonempty; by Euclid infinitely many distinct gaps d carry a nonempty plus line, and the same runs from any Giuga number G ($\delta(Gp) = p + G$). This fixes the census tail: $330, 390, 510, 570 = 30 \cdot \{11, 13, 17, 19\}$ lie on the gaps $d = 41, 43, 47, 49$. (Per-gap infinitude remains open, of Bunyakovsky type.)*

Proposition 12.23 (A difference-36 congruence modulo 72). *Let $n = 6m$ be a Giuga or primary pseudoperfect number with $\gcd(m, 6) = 1$, $n' = n + \varepsilon$ ($\varepsilon = +1$ Giuga, -1 primary pseudoperfect).*

Then $6m' = m + \varepsilon$, and with $m' \equiv \omega(m) \pmod{2}$ this yields $n \equiv 36\omega(n) - 78 \pmod{72}$ on the Giuga side and $n \equiv 36\omega(n) - 66 \pmod{72}$ on the primary pseudoperfect side; in particular equal ω forces equal residue. The congruence is verified on all twelve Giuga numbers and all seven 6-divisible primary pseudoperfect numbers listed in the OEIS (we recomputed the factorisations of the five largest Giuga members; all are squarefree, with $\omega = 7, 7, 8, 8, 8$), and gives, at the modulus 72, the difference-36 arithmetic progression observed by Sondow-MacMillan [26]; their finer modulus-288 pattern remains empirical.

The modulus-72 argument is the $D = 6$ case of a general transport of the line equation across a fixed divisor.

Proposition 12.24 (Divisor transport). *Let $n = Dm$ with D, m coprime squarefree and $n' = n + \varepsilon$ ($\varepsilon = \pm 1$) a quotient-one member. Leibniz transports the line equation to*

$$Dm' = (D - D')m + \varepsilon.$$

- (a) *If $\sigma(D) > 1$ (so $D' > D$; least case $D = 30$), the right side is negative for $m > 1$ while the left is nonnegative; the only escape is $m = 1$, $\varepsilon = +1$. Hence no primary pseudoperfect number is divisible by 30, and the only Giuga number divisible by 30 is 30 itself (elementary; we have not located it in the literature) — consistent with the full known corpus, of which only 30 carries the factor 5.*
- (b) *At a primary pseudoperfect block D (where $D - D' = 1$) the slice $m' = 1$ reads $m = D - \varepsilon$ prime: the two classical chain rules — $D(D + 1)$ primary pseudoperfect when $D + 1$ is prime, $D(D - 1)$ Giuga when $D - 1$ is prime [27, 26] — are the two signs of one transported equation ($1806 = 42 \cdot 43$ and $1722 = 42 \cdot 41$ sit on the same slice $D = 42$).*
- (c) *For any gap d the same transport stratifies the line $n' = n + d$ by divisor blocks D into the steeper lines $Dm' = (D - D')m + d$, a further enumeration coordinate for the genealogy of Proposition 12.17.*

Finally, the form obstruction can be averaged: it eliminates almost every integer, though not the thin stratum where a solution could live.

Proposition 12.25 (Average rarity of form-barrier survivors). *Call a squarefree N blocked at an odd prime ℓ if $\ell \nmid N$, $N' \equiv \pm 2N \pmod{\ell}$, and $(N \mid \ell) = -1$, and a survivor if it is blocked at no odd prime. A blocked N admits no representation $Es^2 + Dd^2 = 4N^2$ (reducing mod ℓ forces N to be a quadratic residue, against $(N \mid \ell) = -1$; this is the genus fragment of Proposition 12.13), so every union of a #307 solution is a survivor. Now $N' \equiv N S_\ell(N) \pmod{\ell}$ with $S_\ell(N) = \sum_{p \mid N} p^{-1}$ an additive function, so blocking at ℓ is an additive-function event ($S_\ell \equiv \pm 2$) twisted by the quadratic character, of limiting density $1/(\ell + 1)$. As $\sum_\ell 1/(\ell + 1)$ diverges (Mertens), the Selberg-Delange/Halász theory of additive functions in residue classes [17] gives that the survivors have natural density zero among the squarefree integers (unconditional), with $\#\{\text{survivors} \leq X\} = O(X/\log \log \log X)$ under a standard — but here unproved — uniformity estimate. Thus the single-prime form obstruction removes almost every squarefree integer. We stress the scope: survivors remain infinite, and a #307 solution — one integer beyond 2.09×10^{56} , in the density-zero stratum $\sigma(N) \geq 2$ — is untouched by such an average statement, which speaks only to the typical integer, not to existence.*

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